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Nearly 12 crore women received safe maternity care

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Quick News

GOVT HIKES WINDFALL TAX: DIESEL RS 55.5, ATF RS 42/L

NEW DELHI: The government on Saturday hiked export duty, or windfall tax, on diesel to Rs 55.5 per litre and on aviation fuel ATF to Rs 42 a litre. The duty hikes would be applicable with immediate effect, the finance ministry said in a notification.

The government had, on March 26, imposed an export duty of Rs 21.50 a litre on diesel, and Rs 29.5 per litre on Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF). The duties were levied to increase domestic availability of the fuel amid the war in West Asia.

They were also aimed at not allowing exporters to take undue advantage due to price differences, as globally crude oil prices had risen since the beginning of the war. **Continued on P4**

ASHA BHOSLE HOSPITALISED WITH CHEST INFECTION

MUMBAI: Legendary playback singer Asha Bhosle was admitted to a private hospital here on Saturday evening due to chest infection and exhaustion, her granddaughter Zanai Bhosle said.

The 92-year-old singer was admitted to Breach Candy hospital in South Mumbai.

Sources had earlier said she suffered cardiac arrest and also had pulmonary problems.

Zanai took to Instagram to share details about Bhosle's health.

"My grandmother, Asha Bhosle due to extreme exhaustion and suffering a chest infection has been admitted to hospital and we request you to value our privacy. Treatment is ongoing and hopefully everything will be well and we shall update you positively," she wrote.

Asha Bhosle, with a career spanning over eight decades, is known for her versatility and has sung many memorable melodies, from romantic songs to ghazals to peppy numbers. Among her most popular songs are 'Abhi Na Jao Chhod Kar', 'In Ankhon Ki Masti', 'Dil Cheez Kya Hai', 'Piya Tu Ab to Aaja', 'Duniya Mein Logon Ko', and 'Zaara Se Jhoom Loon Main', among others.

Bhosle has recorded over 12,000 songs in different Indian languages and has **Continued on P4**

US, Iran talk peace in Pak

HORMUZ DRAMA: US DESTROYERS TRANSIT, IRAN CLAIMS TURNBACK



US Vice President JD Vance, center after arriving for talks with Iranian officials in Islamabad, Pakistan, on Saturday PTI

WAR TO WORDS

- » The Pakistan-brokered talks — the first direct, high-level engagement between the two sides since the 1979 Islamic Revolution — are being watched globally amid increasing expectations of a breakthrough
- » Ahead of the trilateral negotiations in Islamabad, the Vance-led US team and the Iranian delegation headed by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf held separate meetings with Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif

- » 'After Pakistan PM Sharif held separate meetings with both the delegations, formal round of direct negotiations between Iran and the United States has officially begun'
- » Iran's semi-official Tasnim news agency reported that the negotiations have moved beyond general issues and entered technical-level discussions on 'certain topics'

Post ceasefire, 1st Indian vessel crosses Hormuz

NEW DELHI: An India-flagged liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) tanker, Jag Vikram, has crossed the Strait of Hormuz, marking the first such transit by an Indian vessel since a temporary two-week ceasefire between the United States and Iran was announced.

Ship tracking data showed the tanker moved through the strategic waterway between Friday night and Saturday morning and was located in the Gulf of Oman, east of the Strait on Saturday afternoon, proceeding eastwards. The vessel movement was also confirmed by a government statement giving an update on developments in West Asia.

"The India-flagged LPG vessel Jag Vikram has safely crossed the Strait of Hormuz today (Saturday)," it said. **See P2**

Beirut strikes: One left to bury his world



Mourners pray over the six coffins of members of the Al-Jalib family, who were killed Wednesday in Israeli strikes in Beirut, during their funeral in the village of al-Sour, Deir al-Zour province, northeastern Syria AP/PTI

Sole survivor buries wife, four children

DEIR EL-ZOUR: A Syrian man on Saturday buried his wife and four of his five children, killed in the massive wave of Israeli strikes that pounded Beirut earlier this week, laying them to rest in Deir el-Zour province in northeastern Syria.

It was not the homecoming they had anticipated when they fled to Lebanon six years ago.

The bodies, along with that of his six-month pregnant daughter-in-law, arrived in wooden coffins on a bus from Lebanon, their names scribbled on the sides.

Men stood beside the bus crying before the burial procession in al-Sour town, as mourners gathered to offer condolences.

GONE TOGETHER

- » It was not the homecoming they had anticipated when they fled to Lebanon six years ago
- » The bodies, along with that of his six-month pregnant daughter-in-law, arrived in wooden coffins on a bus from Lebanon, their names scribbled on the sides
- » Men stood beside the bus crying before the burial procession in al-Sour town, as mourners gathered to offer condolences

More than 350 people were killed that day, a third being women and children, making it the deadliest day in nearly six weeks of war.

Many of the strikes hit commercial streets and densely populated neighborhoods in central Beirut, far from conflict zones, where repeated Israeli evacuation warnings have been issued since March 2, when the Iran-backed militant group Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel in retaliation for the U.S.-Israeli attacks on Iran. **Continued on P4**

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

ISLAMABAD: Amid a fragile two-week ceasefire, a US delegation led by Vice President JD Vance held historic face-to-face talks with top Iranian negotiators in Pakistan on Saturday to reach a peace agreement to end the war in West Asia that has paralysed global energy markets and disrupted trade.

The Pakistan-brokered talks -- the first direct, high-level engagement between the two sides since the 1979 Islamic Revolution -- are being watched globally amid increasing expectations of a breakthrough.

Ahead of the trilateral negotiations in Islamabad, the Vance-led US team and the Iranian delegation headed by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf held separate meetings with Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif.

"After Pakistan PM Sharif held separate meetings with both the delegations, formal round of direct negotiations between Iran and the United States has officially begun," a senior Pakistani official said.

Pakistan's state-run PTV said Iranian and US officials sat across the table for "landmark peace negotiations." The format of the

breakthrough.

talks was not very clear.

The official cited above said the Pakistan Foreign Office is likely to issue a statement after the conclusion of the first round of talks between the two warring parties.

Iran's semi-official Tasnim news agency reported that the negotiations have moved beyond general issues and entered technical-level discussions on "certain topics".

While Vance is accompanied by Special Envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, President Donald Trump's son-in-law, the Ghalibaf-led Iranian delegation comprised Foreign Minis-

ter Abbas Araghchi, Supreme National Defence Council Secretary Ali Akbar Ahmadian and Central Bank Governor Abdolnaser Hemmati.

The two sides travelled to Islamabad on Saturday for the talks, four days after Iran and the US announced a two-week ceasefire. However, a massive wave of Israeli strikes on Lebanon, killing more than 300 people, has left the truce in tatters.

While Tehran claimed the assault violated the terms of the ceasefire understanding, the US and Israel said Lebanon was not part of the deal. **Continued on P4**

Bihar: At least 13 killed in multi-vehicle collision

KATIHAR (BIHAR): At least 13 people were killed and 30 others injured following a collision involving a bus, a truck, and a pickup van in Bihar's Katihar district on Saturday evening, a police officer said.

The accident took place at 6:30 pm on NH-31 in Kodha block of Katihar, Superintendent of Police Shikhar Choudhary told reporters. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar announced an exgratia of Rs 2 lakh to the next of kin of each the deceased, and Rs 50,000 to each injured. **See P4**

FS MISRI VISITS MAR-A-LAGO

India, US to deepen nuclear ties & explore LPG exports

WASHINGTON: India's Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri discussed furthering energy cooperation with the US in nuclear power and new areas such as coal gasification and LPG exports in his meeting with US Energy Secretary Chris Wright.

Misri's discussion with Wright focused on "advancing energy security, deepening bilateral energy trade, and identifying new avenues to strengthen the India-US Energy Partnership", the Indian Embassy here said in a social media post on Friday.

US Ambassador to India, Sergei Gor, who was also present at the meeting, said America was ready to cooperate with India on civil nuclear cooperation in addition to other areas, such as coal gasification and US LPG exports.

"Great to spend this (Friday) morning with @SecretaryWright and FS Vikram Misri to discuss the future of US-India energy cooperation. After India's historic passage of the SHANTI bill, we are ready to cooperate on civil nuclear in addition to other areas such as coal gasification and US LPG exports," Gor said in a social media post.

Later on Friday night, he hosted Misri at US President Donald Trump's Mar-a-Lago resort in Florida. **Continued on P4**



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor, left, meets Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri at Mar-a-Lago, in Palm Beach, Florida, United States PTI

Rare moment: PM Modi stops to chat with Rahul

Minute-long exchange at Phule tribute event

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A brief conversation initiated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi drew attention during a commemorative event for renowned social reformer Jyotirao Phule at the Parliament House complex here on Saturday.

The interaction stood out as the two leaders are rarely seen speaking to each other beyond exchanging pleasantries at such public events.

When the prime minister arrived to pay floral tributes at



the statue of Phule on the occasion of his birth anniversary, several dignitaries, including Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, were standing in a row.

After greeting everyone with folded hands, Modi stopped near Gandhi and started talking to him. **Continued on P4**

FROZEN FRAME



Fresh snowfall blankets the Atal Tunnel South Portal area at Rohtang, in Kullu district, on Saturday PTI

DRAFT POLICY AIMS FOR CLEAN, ACCESSIBLE TRANSPORT: CM

Delhi's EV reset: No tax, scrap bonus & more...

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a sweeping push to curb air pollution and accelerate clean mobility, the Delhi government on Saturday unveiled a draft Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2026-2030, proposing wide-ranging incentives, tax exemptions and infrastructure expansion to boost the adoption of electric vehicles across the national capital.

At the heart of the proposed policy is a 100 per cent exemption on road tax and registration fees for electric cars priced up to Rs 30 lakh (ex-showroom), a benefit that will remain valid till March 31, 2030. Cars above this price threshold will not be eligible, while strong hybrid vehicles



will receive a 50 per cent tax concession, indicating a phased transition towards full electrification.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the draft policy aims to establish a "clean, accessible and sustainable transport system" in Delhi through a mix of financial incentives, regulatory mandates

and infrastructure development.

The government has earmarked a total outlay of Rs 3,954.25 crore, including Rs 1,236.25 crore for purchase incentives, Rs 1,718 crore for scrapping incentives and Rs 1,000 crore for charging infrastructure, she added.

UP TO RS 1 LAKH SCRAPPING INCENTIVE

In a significant move to encourage the replacement of older polluting vehicles, the policy proposes a scrapping incentive of up to Rs 1 lakh for residents purchasing a new electric car after scrapping BS-IV or older vehicles. The benefit, however, will be limited to the first one lakh eligible applicants.

INCENTIVES FOR ELECTRIC TWO-WHEELERS

Recognising that two-wheelers make up the bulk of Delhi's vehicle population, the policy introduces a declining incentive structure to promote early

adoption. Buyers of electric two-wheelers priced up to Rs 2.25 lakh will receive Rs 10,000 per kWh (up to Rs 30,000) in the first year, which will gradually reduce to Rs 6,600 per kWh (capped at Rs 20,000) in the second year and Rs 3,300 per kWh (up to Rs 10,000) in the third year.

'From April 1, 2028, only electric two-wheelers will be registered in Delhi.'

NO ADDITION OF PETROL, DIESEL VEHICLES TO DELIVERY & RIDE AGGREGATOR FLEETS

The policy also targets high-usage segments such as delivery fleets and public transport. Petrol and diesel vehicles will no longer be added to **Continued on P4**

Bihar bans pvt practice by govt docs

MPOST BUREAU

PATNA: The Bihar government on Saturday announced a complete ban on private practice by doctors employed in government hospitals.

According to a notification issued by the state Health Department, the decision was taken under the state's flagship programme 'Saat Nischay-3' (seven resolves) for the 2025-30 period.

"Under the resolution 'accessible health, secure life', the state has decided to prohibit private practice by government doctors," the notification said.

The department will issue separate guidelines regarding compensation through a non-practising allowance (NPA) for government doctors, subject to approval by the competent authority, it added.

The provision will apply to all government doctors and faculty members in state-run hospitals.

Chief Minister Nitish Kumar had earlier indicated that such a policy would soon be introduced.

Addressing a gathering during his 'Samridhhi Yatra' in West Champaran district in January, Kumar had said the government would bring a new policy aimed at strengthening healthcare infrastructure and curbing private practice by government doctors.

First Indian vessel crosses Strait of Hormuz after US-Iran ceasefire

The tanker moved through the strait between Friday night & Saturday morning & was located in the Gulf of Oman, ship tracking data showed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An India-flagged liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) tanker, Jag Vikram, has crossed the Strait of Hormuz, marking the first such transit by an Indian vessel since a temporary two-week ceasefire between the United States and Iran was announced.

Ship tracking data showed the tanker moved through the strategic waterway between Friday night and Saturday morning and was located in the Gulf of Oman, east of the Strait on Saturday afternoon, proceeding eastwards.

The vessel movement was also confirmed by a government statement giving an update on developments in West Asia.

“The India-flagged LPG vessel Jag Vikram has safely crossed the Strait of Hormuz today (Saturday),” it said. “The vessel is carrying approximately 20,400 tonnes of LPG cargo with 24 seafarers onboard. It is expected to arrive at Mumbai on April 15, 2026.”

Jag Vikram is the ninth Indian vessel to exit the Persian Gulf since early March, while about 15 India-flagged ships remain in the region, awaiting passage.

Owned by Mumbai-based



According to MarineTraffic data, hundreds of vessels remain in the region, including 426 tankers, 34 LPG carriers and 19 LNG vessels

Great Eastern Shipping Company, Jag Vikram is a mid-sized gas carrier with a deadweight capacity of over 26,000 tonnes.

At least 28 India-flagged vessels were in the Strait of Hormuz region when the West Asia conflict erupted, including 24 on the western side and four on the eastern side of the waterway.

Prior to Jag Vikram's transit, eight vessels from the western side and two from the eastern side had managed to sail to safety. Several foreign-flagged ships carrying India-bound

cargo also remain stranded in the Persian Gulf.

According to MarineTraffic data, hundreds of vessels remain in the region, including 426 tankers, 34 LPG carriers and 19 LNG vessels, many of which had been effectively stranded amid the disruption.

The government statement said that port operations across India remain normal, with no congestion reported.

The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways continues to coordinate with the

Highlights

» At least 28 India-flagged vessels were in the Strait of Hormuz region when the West Asia conflict erupted

» 'India-flagged LPG vessel Jag Vikram has safely crossed the strait today (Saturday),' a govt statement said

» Jag Vikram is ninth Indian vessel to exit the Persian Gulf since early March, while about 15 India-flagged ships remain in the region

Ministry of External Affairs, Indian Missions, and maritime stakeholders to ensure seafarer welfare and uninterrupted maritime operations,” it added.

India, the world's third-largest energy consumer and fourth-largest gas user, imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil, around half of its natural gas needs and nearly 60 per cent of its liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) requirement, underscoring its dependence on overseas supplies.

More than half of crude

imports, about 40 per cent of gas and up to 85-90 per cent of LPG shipments come from Gulf countries and pass through the Strait of Hormuz, a key global energy corridor that was shut during the West Asia conflict.

The United States and Iran earlier this week agreed to a conditional two-week ceasefire that includes reopening the Strait for shipping.

India curtailed LPG supplies to commercial users such as hotels and restaurants after disruptions to Gulf energy flows, before restoring about 70 per cent of pre-crisis volumes as alternative supplies were secured.

Natural gas supplies were initially cut to industries, including fertiliser plants, to prioritise CNG for transport and piped cooking gas for households. Supplies to fertiliser units have since been partially restored, with operating urea plants receiving about 80 per cent of recent average consumption, while overall allocation to the sector has been raised to around 95 per cent this week.

Gas availability to other industrial and commercial users has also been increased gradually, though it remains below normal levels.

India allows Iranian oil tankers to berth for Reliance: Sources

The US last month temporarily waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea to ease oil prices

NEW DELHI/LONDON: India's shipping ministry has granted special permission to four vessels carrying Iranian oil - as requested by Reliance Industries to berth at the western port of Sikka, three industry sources said.

India, the world's third-biggest oil importer and consumer, has not received a cargo from Tehran since May 2019 following US pressure not to buy Iranian crude.

However, the US last month temporarily waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea to ease oil prices. The waiver is due to expire on April 19.

India's oil ministry, shipping ministry and Reliance did not respond to requests for comment.

Iranian oil is often transported by a shadow fleet of vessels that lack internationally recognised insurance and safety certifications. But this requires special permission from the government as exemptions are required under Indian rules for the berthing of ships.

One of the sources said the shipping ministry has granted a special one-time exemption to vessels requested by Reliance, operator of the world's biggest refining complex, due to the emergency situation created by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Apart from Comoros-flagged aframax Kaviz and



One of the sources said the shipping ministry has granted a special one-time exemption to vessels requested by Reliance

Curacao-flagged very large crude carrier (VLCC) Lenore, permission has been granted to Iran-flagged VLCCs Felicity and Hedy, a second source said.

All four US-sanctioned vessels are more than 20 years old. Each VLCC supertanker can carry a maximum of 2 million barrels of oil, *Reuters* reported. India typically requires tankers that are more than 20 years old to have seaworthiness certification from a member of the industry's leading body, the International Association of Classification Societies, or an entity authorised by India's maritime administration.

The Hedy has been positioned near Chabahar port

Key Points

» Iranian oil is often transported by a shadow fleet of vessels that lack internationally recognised certifications

» But this requires special permission from govt as exemptions are required under Indian rules for the berthing of ships

» Iranian tanker Hedy has been positioned near Chabahar port since April 1 & Felicity was seen near Chabahar since April 3

since April 1 and Felicity was seen near Chabahar since April 3, according to analysis from US advocacy group United Against Nuclear Iran, which monitors Iran-related tanker traffic through ship and satellite tracking.

The Kaviz exited the Gulf on Thursday, while the Lenore loaded crude from Iran's Kharg Island on March 20, UANI senior adviser Charlie Brown said. However, another source said, despite the grant of permission, it was not certain Reliance would process Iranian oil, as it wants to ensure that transactions are sanctions-compliant and are in line with Indian rules.

AGENCIES

UJVN Ltd's MD reviews Lakhwar Project



NEW DELHI: To fast-track ongoing works, UJVN Ltd MD Ajay Kumar Singh on April 11 inspected the 300 MW Lakhwar Multipurpose Project, marking his second visit since taking charge.

Singh reviewed key components, including the underground powerhouse, diversion structures, cofferdam and shear zone shaft. He assessed materials, machinery and manpower, and stressed strict adherence to quality and safety standards while directing officials to speed up execution.

At a review meeting, he said the project is a priority for both the Centre and the Uttarakhand government, with clear instructions to complete it within the stipulated timeline.

He urged officials to ensure quality alongside deadlines so that benefits reach Uttarakhand and six other states on time.

He also called for better coordination & asked officials to promptly flag any bottlenecks for swift resolution. The project is expected to boost power generation, irrigation, drinking water supply and flood control, driving regional development.

MPOST

Goyal holds talks with Saudi trade minister on boosting supply chains

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday held discussions with Saudi Arabia's Trade Minister Majid bin Abdullah Al Qassabi on ways to strengthen supply chains disrupted due to the West Asia crisis, after holding talks with his counterparts from the UAE, Bahrain and Kuwait.

All these countries are members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) with which India is negotiating a free trade agreement.

The commerce ministry, in a statement, said that Goyal had a virtual call with Qassabi.

“The Ministers reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening bilateral trade and expressed optimism for early progress in the India-GCC FTA negotiations,” it said.

Both sides noted the strain



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

Goyal highlighted India's steps to support exports to Saudi Arabia and the Gulf region

conflict has put on regional supply chains and stressed the need for an early recovery through coordinated efforts to ensure smooth trade flows, it said.

Goyal highlighted India's steps to support exports to Saudi Arabia and the Gulf region.

The joint attack launched by the US and Israel on Iran had led to severe disruptions in the movement of ships in international waters, particularly to the West Asian nations.

The conflict has posed challenges for exporters to ship goods to the Gulf region, with which India had a bilateral trade of \$178 billion in 2024-25 (\$56.87 billion exports and \$121.67 billion imports).

The major sectors which are under stress include petroleum products, chemicals and plastics, engineering goods, rice, pharma and gems and jewellery. The six countries in this region are the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar and Kuwait.

PTI

US likely to extend waiver for buying Russian oil to temper Iran war shock, says sources

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump's administration is likely to extend as soon as Friday a waiver allowing countries to buy some sanctioned Russian oil and petroleum products, two sources familiar with the matter told *Reuters*.

The US Treasury Department has allowed purchases of Russian oil and products at sea since mid-March with a 30-day waiver that expires on April 11, part of efforts to control global energy prices during the US-Israeli war with Iran.

Russia's presidential envoy Kirill Dmitriev had said the original waiver would free 100 million barrels of Russian crude, equal to almost a day's worth of global output.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent met with Trump



in the White House on Thursday to talk about extending the waiver, and they agreed it was a good idea, one of the sources said, asking not to be named.

Officials at the White House and Treasury Department did not immediately comment on the matter.

Oil prices have spiked since the start of the war due to the partial closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which about 20 per cent of the world's oil and gas had been shipped daily before the conflict.

The war is creating the biggest oil supply disruption in history, the 32-nation Interna-

tional Energy Agency has said.

Rising fuel prices are a major concern for Trump and his Republican party leading into midterm elections in November.

The waivers have been criticized by politicians at home and abroad as they could complicate the West's efforts to deprive Russia of revenue for its war in Ukraine and put Washington at odds with its allies.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen has said now is not the time to relax sanctions against Russia.

The US also waived sanctions on Iranian oil at sea on March 20 for 30 days, in an effort to control prices, spurring criticism from lawmakers from both political parties.

AGENCIES

Work resumes on Bhutan's Punatsangchhu-I hydropower project after 7-year suspension

NEW DELHI: Work on Bhutan's 1,200 MW Punatsangchhu-I hydropower project has resumed after a seven-year suspension, with India's Power Minister Manohar Lal attending a key concrete pouring ceremony marking the restart of dam construction.

The revival of the India-funded project, stalled since 2019 due to geological challenges, is seen as a major milestone in bilateral energy cooperation and is expected to pave the way for completion within five years. According to an official statement, Manohar Lal, during his visit to Bhutan, visited the project site, which is the largest joint hydropower

venture between the two countries and is expected to enhance Bhutan's hydropower capacity substantially upon completion.

The minister attended a concrete pouring ceremony at Punatsangchhu-I on April 10, signalling the restart of dam construction, which had been suspended since 2019 due to geological challenges. The project, Bhutan's largest hydropower venture funded by India, is expected to be completed within five years.

The minister said the project reflects strong India-Bhutan energy cooperation, highlighting India's financial and technical support and the joint efforts to advance construction safely.

At the Punatsangchhu-II project, jointly inaugurated in November 2025 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Bhutan's King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, he reviewed operations, noting it is already generating electricity and revenue, including exports to India.

Punatsangchhu-I, a run-of-the-river project with an installed capacity of 1,200 MW, is expected to boost Bhutan's hydropower capacity by about 30 per cent to nearly 4,700 MW and generate around 5,670 million units annually.

Funded by India with a 40 per cent grant and 60 per cent loan, the project had reached

over 93 per cent financial progress and nearly 88 per cent physical completion as of February 2026 before work resumed.

The project was approved at a cost of Rs 9,375.57 crore (December 2013 price level). As of February 2026, financial progress stood at Rs 8,785.19 crore, or 93.7 per cent, while physical progress was 87.75 per cent. A revised cost estimate is currently under examination.

The minister also visited the historic Wangdue Phodrang Dzong during his trip. The surplus power generated by the PHEP-I will be sold to India at a mutually determined price, to be agreed at the time of project commissioning.

PTI

NAGPUR: India's fisheries exports have risen from about Rs 60,000 crore to Rs 68,000 crore as the country tapped new markets following US tariff measures, Union Minister Satya Pal Singh Baghel claimed on Saturday.

The government aims to achieve Rs 1 lakh crore in fisheries exports over the next five years, he said on the sidelines of the second National Veterinary, Dairy and Fisheries Symposium 2026 in Nagpur. India is exporting prawns, tuna and other fish varieties to several parts of the world, including Europe, Latin America, Middle East & Asia, he said.

“India's fisheries exports



have increased by 25 per cent as we began exploring new markets soon after US tariffs were imposed,” he said at the symposium at the Maharashtra Animal and Fishery Sciences University here. However, he did not specify the period of the growth.

Later, the minister told the media that Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Odisha, Lakshadweep, and the Andaman and

Nicobar Islands are major fisheries export hubs in the country, covering both inland and marine production. The minister of state for fisheries, animal husbandry and dairying said that top officials from his ministry have been visiting new markets & tapping them for exports.

“Our fisheries exports have risen from about Rs 60,000 crore to Rs 68,000 crore US tariff measures,” he claimed.

The government is aiming to hit Rs 1 lakh crore in fisheries exports over the next five years, he said. The minister also highlighted various initiatives being taken to strengthen the fisheries, animal husbandry and dairy sectors.

PTI

Govt, exporters discuss market access, diversification at Seafood Exporters Meet 2026

The meet was organised to provide a structured platform for interaction between the govt & industry stakeholders and to obtain feedback from exporters

NEW DELHI: The Department of Fisheries under the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying organised the Seafood Exporters Meet 2026 at Ambedkar Bhawan to deliberate on challenges and growth strategies for marine exports.

The meeting was attended by Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Ministers of State Prof. S P Singh Baghel and George Kurian, and

Union Fisheries Secretary Dr. Abhilaksh Likhi.

The platform enabled interaction between government and industry stakeholders on issues such as market access, pricing pressures, compliance requirements, value addition and export diversification, including expansion from island territories, the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) and high seas.

Rajiv Ranjan Singh commended exporters for sus-

taining growth despite global uncertainties, noting that seafood exports have remained robust, driven largely by non-US markets. He stressed the need for continued diversification and strict adherence to regulatory norms, including antibiotic bans and traceability systems. He said EEZ Rules are being operationalised through access passes, with priority to cooperative societies.

Highlighting opportuni-

CLOSER LOOK

» Union Minister for Fisheries pointed to export potential of high-value species like tuna from Andaman & Nicobar

» Rajiv Ranjan Singh called for improved onboard handling, cold-chain infra, packaging and value addition

» He urged exporters to work towards the Rs 1 lakh crore export target, with support from institutions such as EIC, NCDC, NABARD & Ministry of Food Processing Industries

ties, Singh pointed to the export potential of high-value species

like tuna from the Andaman & Nicobar Islands and called

for improved onboard handling, cold-chain infrastructure, packaging and value addition. He urged exporters to work towards the Rs 1 lakh crore export target, with support from institutions such as EIC, NCDC, NABARD and the Ministry of Food Processing Industries. Investments following a recent investors' meet in the islands are expected to boost sea-cage culture, pearl farming and deep-sea fishing.

Minister of State George Kurian said efforts are underway to position fisheries as a high-value sector, emphasising compliance, certifications, logistics and value-chain development.

Dr. Abhilaksh Likhi said a focused market diversification strategy has been developed with MPEDA, EIC and the Department of Commerce, supported by diplomatic outreach to nearly 40 countries.

He highlighted opportunities in ready-to-eat and value-added segments and said the Department will facilitate linkages between exporters and Indian Missions abroad.

Industry stakeholders flagged issues including tariff and non-tariff barriers, high compliance costs, processing gaps and logistics constraints, while seeking streamlined procedures and targeted support to boost exports.

MPOST

Recycling, emission tracking: With EV push, Delhi plugs into cleaner future

Policy maps recycling ecosystem and real-time emission assessment

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi's draft Electric Vehicle Policy 2026, released on Saturday, emphasises building an environmentally sound battery recycling ecosystem by assigning clear responsibilities to the Environment Department and the Delhi Pollution Control Committee.

The policy, released by the Delhi government, mandates strict compliance with the Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022, particularly focusing on Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR).

According to the draft, the Environment Department has been tasked with ensuring that original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) and other obligated entities adhere to these rules, including proper reporting and safe handling of used batteries.

The draft stated, "The Environment Department shall assess and periodically



An electric vehicle amid traffic on a road on Saturday

PTI

quantify the emission reductions achieved through electric vehicle registrations under the Delhi EV Policy 2026."

The department shall develop a transparent methodology to evaluate impacts on air pollution, enabling evidence-based assessment of the environmental outcomes and the policy's overall effectiveness, the draft read.

The DPCC, on the other

hand, will serve as the implementing and facilitating agency for on-ground battery collection and processing systems.

According to the draft, the committee will develop a framework to establish battery collection centres across Delhi through a public-private partnership model, with an aim to make disposal more accessible and systematic for consumers and businesses alike.

Scrap old cars, get Rs 1L

NEW DELHI: Residents of Delhi will get up to Rs 1 lakh as scrapping incentive on purchasing a new electric car in exchange for scrapping their old BS-IV and below vehicles, under the draft EV policy released by the city government.

According to it, the incentive will be applicable if the purchase is made within six months of issuance of the Certificate of Deposit (CoD) from an authorised scrapping facility.

It stated that a scrapping incentive of Rs 1,00,000 will be provided for the purchase of a new electric car, subject to an ex-factory price not exceeding Rs 30 lakh. The benefit will be available for scrapping of Delhi-registered BS-IV and below cars and will be limited to the first 1,00,000 eligible applicants under the policy.

MPOST

Meanwhile, all new infrastructure projects undertaken by urban local bodies, including MCD and NDMC, will be required to be equipped for electric vehicle charging.

According to the draft policy, departments, autonomous bodies and civic agencies including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and Delhi Canton-

ment Board will have to ensure that new civil projects are EV-charging-ready, with adequate electrical capacity for installing charging infrastructure.

Separately, the draft policy proposes a wider framework for developing charging and battery swapping infrastructure, with Delhi Transco Limited designated as the nodal agency for planning and coordination.

Mercury climbs up, 40°C likely next week

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Capital continued to see a rise in the temperature on Saturday, with forecasts by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) suggesting a further rise in the coming days.

Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum temperature of 34.7 degrees Celsius, 1.4 degrees below the normal and 1.9 degrees more than a day before.

The minimum temperature was logged at 18.6 degrees Celsius, 2.4 degrees below normal, but a 2.3 degree rise from the day before. Other weather stations also logged a significant rise in both maximum and minimum temperatures.

Palam recorded a maximum of 34.4 degrees Celsius, a 2.6 degree rise from Friday and a minimum of 19.5 degrees Celsius, 3.9 degrees more than the day before. Lodhi Road recorded a minimum of 17.8 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees rise from the day before.

Meanwhile, THE IMD has forecast the minimum temperature to be around 18-22 degrees Celsius by Sunday and 20-22 degrees Celsius by Tuesday. The maximum temperature is likely



5-year-old dead, 1 injured as balcony of house collapses

NEW DELHI: A five-year-old child was killed, and another was injured after a balcony of an old house collapsed in the Wazirpur area of northwest Delhi on Saturday, police said.

According to police, a PCR call was received at Bharat Nagar police station regarding a jhuggi collapse at JJ Colony.

A police team rushed to the spot and shifted two children to Deep Chand Bandhu Hospital, where one child, identified as Divyanshu (5), was declared brought dead, while the other, Rinki (10), is undergoing treatment.

Crime Team and FSL officials inspected the spot and collected exhibits, police said, adding that a case has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and investigation is in progress.

Locals said the incident occurred at around 11 am when some children were playing in a lane near the structure, and the balcony came crashing down. "Children were playing in the gali near the old house when the balcony suddenly collapsed with a loud noise. Two children were under the debris," an eyewitness said.

AGENCIES

Experts welcome EV policy, say execution is real challenge

NEW DELHI: Environmental experts have largely welcomed the Delhi government's draft Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2026, particularly its focus on battery recycling and lifecycle management, while cautioning that its success will depend heavily on enforcement.

Radhe Shyam Sharma, head of the Department of Environmental Studies at Delhi University, described that including "battery recycling" in the policy as "one of the most consequential parts", noting that it shifts attention from vehicle adoption to the environmental risks associated with battery disposal. "This is one of the most consequential parts of the policy, as it moves beyond vehicle adoption to address battery lifecycle management through provisions on Extended Producer Responsibility, collection centres, standard operating procedures, and traceability systems," Sharma said.

The draft policy places strong emphasis on creating a structured battery recycling ecosystem, with the Environment Department tasked with enforcing Battery Waste Management Rules and monitoring emissions reductions, while the

Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) will facilitate battery collection centres and issue standard operating procedures for safe handling and recycling. The policy mandates strict compliance with the Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022, particularly focusing on Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) and has tasked the Environment Department to ensure that original equipment manufacturers and other obligated entities adhere to these rules, including proper reporting and safe handling of used batteries. Highlighting the risks of improper battery disposal, Sharma said provisions relating to collection centres and standardised handling protocols could play a crucial role.

Echoing similar views, Sunil Dahiya, founder and lead analyst at think tank Envirocatalysts, said the policy marks a significant step in linking clean mobility with broader environmental goals. "By addressing vehicular emissions, a primary pollution source, the government is finally ensuring the transport sector takes ownership of its responsibility to provide a livable environment," he said.

AGENCIES

Delhi Police upskills force with technology, forensics training drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a push to build a more professional and technology-driven force, the Crime Branch of Delhi Police on Saturday conducted a day-long training session aimed at strengthening investigative skills and digital policing capabilities.

Held at Adarsh Auditorium at Police Headquarters on Jai Singh Road, the session focused on the use of advanced digital applications and portals, as well as best practices in investigation and the collection and preservation of forensic evidence. Officers from across districts and specialised investigation units participated.

The programme was conducted under the supervision



of Devesh Chandra Srivastava, IPS, Special Commissioner of Police (Crime), highlighting the department's emphasis on leveraging technology to enhance crime prevention, investigation, and overall policing efficiency in the capital.

A total of 458 personnel attended the session, including senior officers and inspectors from various units. Experts from multiple agencies led

specialised modules covering financial investigations, digital tools, and forensic protocols.

Officials from NATGRID briefed participants on the use of applications such as GANDIVA and Sudarshan, along with data integration across agencies. The session also included inputs on handling organised crime cases under MCOCA, procedures for forensic evidence collection.

Daylight armed robbery Hari Nagar case cracked

NEW DELHI: Police arrested three people for their alleged involvement in a daylight armed robbery in west Delhi's Hari Nagar area, an official said on Saturday.

The incident took place on April 4 when three masked men, armed with knives, robbed a man. Police recovered the looted gold 'kada', cash and weapons used in the crime.

A team was formed after registering a case. The team analysed footage from over 200

CCTV cameras installed in and around the area and tracked the movement of the accused before and after the incident.

"Despite the accused concealing their identities and using a motorcycle with an obscured registration number, police relied on technical surveillance and local intelligence to identify them," a senior officer said.

Subsequently, raids were conducted at multiple locations across Delhi, leading to the arrest.

AGENCIES

NDMC plans major makeover of Khan Market

NEW DELHI: Delhi's posh Khan Market is set for a makeover, with authorities planning a series of infrastructure upgrades aimed at improving pedestrian movement and reducing frequent disruptions in the high-footfall shopping hub, officials said.

The New Delhi Municipal Council is considering the development of a dedicated walkway along the circumference of the market, around 300 metres long, after completion of a pilot project currently

Night-time washing and deep cleaning are being carried out regularly

underway on the front side of the market, they said.

They added that on the front side of the market, granite cobblestones are also being laid, with the work expected to be completed within the next few weeks.

"The walkway is likely to be constructed using granite cobblestones or gran-

ite blocks at least 2.5 inches thick, to ensure durability and ease of movement for visitors," officials said.

NDMC vice-chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said that the series of infrastructure improvements is expected to provide a better experience in the coveted market for shoppers and establish a new devel-

opment model. Officials said that alongside this, work is underway to upgrade the middle lane in a manner that would reduce the need for frequent road cutting in the future, particularly for utility services. The redesign is aimed at minimising disruptions to traders and shoppers, they said.

In addition, night-time washing and deep cleaning are being carried out regularly to maintain cleanliness in the market area.

MPOST

Inter-state narcotics syndicate busted

NEW DELHI: An interstate narcotics syndicate operating between Bihar and Delhi was busted, with the arrest of its alleged main supplier from Bihar's Madhepura, an official said on Saturday.

The breakthrough came during the investigation of a case registered on March 24 at Hauz Qazi police station, when a man identified as Mohammad Ali was apprehended while allegedly consuming smack during routine patrolling. During the interrogation, Ali disclosed that he had procured the contraband from a supplier identified as Sonu, who operated near Paharganj. "Acting on this lead, police launched a sustained operation to unravel the supply chain," the officer said.

Based on inputs, three people -- Binod Kumar, Sonu Kumar Mandal and Sanjit Kumar -- were arrested from the Todapur area on March 27. Police recovered over eight kg of cannabis and 10 grams of heroin from their possession, they said. Further investigation revealed that the contraband was being sourced both from Delhi and Bihar.

AGENCIES

35 years on the run: 1991 murder case solved, accused arrested

Proclaimed offender traced, held in Ludhiana after manhunt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police cracked a 35-year-old murder case with the arrest of a proclaimed offender who allegedly killed his landlady and injured her son in a robbery case in 1991, an official said on Saturday.

The accused had been identified as Chhavi Lal Verma. Police said that he deliberately avoided returning to his native place for years to evade arrest and also skipped major family events, including his children's marriages.

"The case dates back to August 2, 1991, when a PCR call was received regarding a violent incident at West Vinod Nagar. A police team rushed to the spot and found the woman lying unconscious with multiple stab injuries on her neck, while her son, aged around 18-20 years at the time, had sustained stab wounds on his face," the police officer said.

Both victims were shifted to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash (LNJP)

In Short

» Police said that he deliberately avoided returning to his native place for years to evade arrest and also skipped family events, including his children's marriages

» Police said he targeted the woman with the intention of robbery,



believing that she possessed substantial cash as her husband was residing abroad

Hospital, where the woman succumbed to her injuries, while her son survived after treatment.

During the investigation, it emerged that Verma, aged around 25 at the time of the incident, was a tenant in the victim's house in east Delhi's Trilok Puri area. He had attacked the duo with a sharp-edged weapon, police said.

Police said he targeted the woman with the intention of robbery, believing that she possessed substantial cash as her husband was residing abroad.

"When the landlady and her son resisted, he attacked them repeatedly with a chopper and fled," the officer said.

Following the incident, Verma went into hiding and managed to evade arrest despite efforts by the local police. He was eventually declared a proclaimed offender by a Delhi court on May 10, 1996.

"The case remained pending for decades, with the accused successfully staying under the radar by constantly changing his identity and location," the officer said.

Three held in separate digital arrest, scams

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an interstate cyber fraud network and arrested three people in connection with separate cases of digital arrest and investment frauds scams involving over Rs 80 lakh, an official said on Saturday.

In the first case, a fraud of Rs 47.74 lakh was reported in February, where the victim was duped by fraudsters posing as law enforcement officials. The accused threatened the victim with a digital arrest and coerced him into transferring money.

During the investigation, police traced Rs 18.74 lakh to a bank account in Badaun, Uttar Pradesh. Based on technical surveillance and financial trail analysis, Gautam Singh (25) was arrested on April 8.

He had provided his bank account and SIM card to co-accused Farhan for Rs 15,000, police said. Farhan (30) was later apprehended from Noida for arranging mule accounts used to route the cheated money. Transactions were conducted remotely using unregistered mobile numbers to evade detection, police said.

City Briefs

MAN TRAPPED UNDER UPROOTED TREE IN UTTAM NAGAR RESCUED

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old man, trapped under an uprooted tree in West Delhi's Uttam Nagar area, was rescued on Friday afternoon, officials from the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said. "A call was received at 4.36 pm regarding the incident at A-Block cremation ground near a gurudwara in the area," a DFS official said, adding that two fire tenders were rushed to the spot. A tree got uprooted, possibly due to strong winds and a man, identified as Kallu, got trapped under it. He was later pulled out after the branches were cut, officials said.

JNU MARKS BIRTH ANNIVERSARY OF DR BR AMBEDKAR WITH EVENT

NEW DELHI: Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) commemorated the birth anniversary of B. R. Ambedkar, paying tribute to the architect of the Indian Constitution through a series of events on campus. The programme featured a formal ceremony, including floral tributes and speeches highlighting Dr. Ambedkar's contributions to social justice, equality and constitutional values. The event was attended by university officials, faculty members and students. Speakers emphasised the continued relevance of Dr Ambedkar's ideas in addressing societal issues.



‘PEOPLE SHOULD REMAIN CALM AND UNITED’

Just like we handled COVID, we can face West Asia crisis: Rajnath

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday asserted that India is fully prepared to deal with any emergency situation and has adequate reserves to handle challenges arising from global conflicts.

Addressing the annual function of Jan Kalyan Mahasamiti in Gomtinagar here, Singh said, “The country has sufficient reserves to deal with any emergency situation. No need to pay attention to rumours.”

Referring to ongoing global tensions, including conflicts in West Asia, he said, “No country in the world is untouched by wars such as those involving Israel; even the United States is facing challenges, but India has accepted these challenges.”

He advised that people should remain calm and united in the face of any temporary



Defence minister Rajnath Singh during the annual celebration event of the Jan Kalyan Maha Samiti, Gomti Nagar, in Lucknow, Saturday

Highlights

» ‘The country has sufficient reserves to deal with any emergency situation. No need to pay attention to rumours’

» Even if there is some short-term difficulty, the people of the country need to stand with full strength and patience, Rajnath said

disruptions. “Even if there is some short-term difficulty, the people of the country need to stand with full strength and patience,” he said.

Reassuring citizens, the defence minister said, “As long as our government is in power, no major crisis will arise in the

country. We successfully handled COVID, and we are ready to face whatever is happening in West Asia.”

Citing global assessments, he said, “The World Bank has said that India is capable of dealing with crises.”

Highlighting the country’s

economic resilience, Singh stated, “The world is going through a global crisis, but even in this period, India is the fastest-growing economy. This is a matter of pride for us.”

Singh praised the development works carried out under the “double-engine” govern-

ments led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, saying their contributions need no elaboration.

“There was a time when Uttar Pradesh was a hub of mafias, but today it has become a hub of saints and seers. Uttar Pradesh was once called a ‘BIMARU’ state, but now wherever you go, people say that to a large extent it has become an ‘Uttam Pradesh’ (developed state),” Singh said.

Regarding defence manufacturing, Singh announced that the production of the BrahMos missile has started in Lucknow, and the first batch has been handed over to the armed forces.

He further mentioned that several ancillary units related to defence equipment are expected to be set up with support from the state government led by Adityanath.

UP: Elderly man ‘holds on’ to deceased daughter for months

Fills home with garbage to avoid suspicion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MEERUT: A 76-year-old man allegedly kept the body of his daughter at his home here following her death from apparent ailment over four months back, police said on Saturday.

They said the man allegedly locked the home and left the area soon after his daughter’s death, and returned recently.

The elderly man — identified as Uday Bhanu Biswas (76), a native of West Bengal — retired as an administrative officer in the education department. He resided in Teli Mohalla area under Sadar Bazar police station limits with his daughter, Priyanka Biswas (35), who was a private teacher.

Preliminary investigations revealed that the woman allegedly died on December

1, 2025, apparently due to illness. However, her father neither informed anyone of her passing, nor performed her last rites -- staying at the house with the body for several days, using perfume to mask the foul odour.

Police said the accused later filled his house with garbage to avoid suspicion before leaving for Haridwar, from where he had recently returned.

On Friday, some of his relatives visited the house. Upon detecting a strong stench emanating from the premises, they alerted the police. Circle Officer (Cantonment) Naveena Shukla said when questioned about his daughter, he initially evaded the subject. However, he eventually revealed that his daughter had died due to illness, and he had locked her body inside one of the rooms of the house.

Bihar: 13 people killed, 30 injured in multi-vehicle collision in Katihar district

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KATIHAR: At least 13 people were killed and 30 others injured following a collision involving a bus, a truck, and a pickup van in Bihar’s Katihar district on Saturday evening, a police officer said.

The accident took place at 6:30 pm on NH-31 in Kodha block of Katihar. Superintendent of Police Shikhar Choudhary took reporters.

Chief Minister Nitish Kumar announced an exgratia of Rs 2 lakh to the next of kin of each the deceased, and Rs 50,000 to each injured. While initial reports said seven people died in the accident, six of the injured succumbed during treatment.

A local police official said those travelling in the pickup van were coming from the neighbouring Purnea district.

He said that how the



People pull passengers from the mangled remains of a bus after its collision with a truck and a pickup van, killing at least 13 people and injuring 30 others, in Katihar district, Bihar, Saturday

accident occurred is being investigated. It is suspected that the bus driver, who is among the injured people, lost control of the vehicle leading to the crash.

According to a statement issued by the district police, all the injured people have been taken to the nearest government hospital in Purnea.

Officials are trying to ascertain the identity of the deceased, the statement said.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar expressed grief over the deaths of people in the accident and announced an exgratia for the kin of the deceased.

“The chief minister... announced an ex gratia of

SIR phase 2: Voters’ list of 12 states/UTs pruned by over 10%

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The combined voters’ list of nine states and three Union territories has been pruned by 10.2 per cent following the SIR exercise carried out by the Election Commission, with over 60 lakh dead voters removed, data shared by the poll authority and its state officials shows.

When phase II of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls was announced by the EC on October 27, the voter base across the 12 states and UTs stood at more than 50.99 crore.

Post the exercise, the voters’ list stands at 45.81 crore -- a decline of over 5.18 crore. In percentage terms, the electoral rolls have been reduced by 10.2 per cent.

As many as 66,88,636 deceased electors have been removed from the rolls, with the maximum of 25.47 lakh from Uttar Pradesh, followed by 24.16 lakh from poll-going West Bengal.

Additionally, 63.16 lakh names were deleted following

Post the exercise, the voters’ list stands at 45.81 crore -- a decline of over 5.18 crore. In percentage terms, the electoral rolls have been reduced by 10.2 per cent

objections and adjudication during the SIR exercise.

The second phase of SIR has now been completed with the final electoral rolls of Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Kerala, Puducherry, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Goa published on different dates.

Uttar Pradesh was the last state to release its final rolls on Friday.

While the exercise, which kept the EC in the news, had earlier been completed in Bihar, the second phase covering the above-mentioned 12

states and Union territories, with nearly 51 crore electors, has now concluded.

The remaining 40 crore electors will be covered across 17 states and five Union territories when the SIR kicks off, likely after this month’s polls to five Assemblies.

These states and UTs are: Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Ladakh, Maharashtra, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Delhi, Odisha, Punjab, Sikkim, Tripura, Telangana and Uttarakhand.

In Assam, a “special revision”, instead of the SIR, was completed on February 10.

Due to a variety of reasons, the SIR exercise in the nine states and three Union territories has seen frequent tweaking in schedules.

Like Bihar, political parties have approached the Supreme Court, challenging the exercise in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Cheetah gives birth to 4 cubs at MP’s Kuno park

First recorded birth in wild at sanctuary

SHEOPUR: A 24-month-old Indian-born cheetah gave birth to four cubs at the Kuno National Park on Saturday, marking the first recorded cheetah birth in the wild at the sanctuary in Madhya Pradesh, officials said.

“A historic moment unfolds at Kuno National Park as an Indian-born female Cheetah of Gamini, aged 25 months, has given birth to four cubs in the wild—marking a major milestone in India’s cheetah conservation journey,” elated Union Environment and Forest Minister Bhupender Yadav wrote on X.

This took the number of cheetahs in India to 57, officials said. The female cheetah who gave birth to the litter on Saturday is an offspring of the South African-born Gamini.

The minister mentioned that since cheetahs were first brought to the KNP from



Africa in 2022, this was the “first recorded birth in the wild” and also the “first such instance involving an Indian-born female.”

“This is a significant step toward achieving the core objectives of the project—survival and breeding under natural conditions,” Yadav further said in his post on X.

The development reflected the growing adaptation of cheetahs to Indian conditions, the minister said, adding that it was a testament to the dedication and tireless efforts of the managers, veterinarians and field staff at Kuno.

MPOST

From Page 1 US, Iran talk peace...

Earlier, both delegations were received at the Nur Khan airbase by Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar, Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir and Interior Minister Mohsin Raza Naqvi.

In his meeting with the Iranian delegation, Prime Minister Sharif affirmed Pakistan’s sincere resolve to continue playing its role as a mediator towards achieving meaningful results from the peace talks. Sharif, during his meeting with the American delegation, expressed hope that the talks between the US and Iran would lead to a durable peace in West Asia.

In a related development, Mohammad Reza Aref, Iran’s first vice president, said the peace talks could produce a deal if the American side worked in the interest of the US in sync with President Trump’s America First approach.

“However, if we face representatives of ‘Israel First’, there will be no deal,” he said on social media. Aref cautioned that the world will face “greater costs” if there is no peace deal.

Tasnim news agency earlier reported that negotiations between Iran and the US will not begin until Tehran’s “preconditions,” including stopping Israeli hostilities against Lebanon and the de-freezing of Iranian assets, are met.

Quoting an “informed source”, it later claimed that the American side has agreed to release Iran’s frozen assets. However, there is no confirmation yet on the report.

The US delegation also comprised Andrew Baker, the Deputy National Security Advisor to the President, and Michael Vance, Special Advisor to the Vice President for Asian Affairs.

A full suite of US experts on relevant subject areas is present in Islamabad, according to US officials. Earlier, Parliament Speaker Ghalibaf shared a photo from inside the aeroplane while en route to Pakistan. In the photograph, he is seen standing in front of images of the Minab School students killed in strikes, which were placed on the aeroplane seats.

“My companions on this flight — Minab 168,” Ghalibaf posted on social media with the photograph. President Trump has already cautioned that the US will resume its military action against Iran if the talks do not produce a peace deal.

Before departing for Pakistan, Vance said he was looking forward to the negotiations and hoped they would be “positive.” “As the US president said, if the Iranians are willing to negotiate in good faith, we’re certainly willing to extend an open hand. If they’re going to try to play us, they’re going to find that the negotiating team is not that receptive,” Vance said before board-

ing his plane for Islamabad. After arriving in Islamabad early Saturday, Ghalibaf told reporters about the issue of trust with the US, reminding them of Iran’s past experience with that country.

“Twice within less than a year, in the middle of negotiations, and despite the Iranian side’s good faith, they attacked us,” he said, adding: “We have goodwill, but we do not have trust (in Americans).” He said if the American side is ready for a “genuine agreement,” then it would see Tehran’s readiness for it.

Iran has laid out a 10-point plan for the talks that included demands for the withdrawal of US forces from West Asia, the lifting of sanctions against Iran, and allowing it to control the Strait of Hormuz. Pakistan led the diplomatic push to bring the two sides to the table, which became possible after an appeal by Prime Minister Sharif earlier this week, leading to a pause in the fighting.

Beirut strikes...

The father, Hamad al-Jalib, survived because he was away fetching a gas canister while working as the building’s concierge. When he heard that a strike had hit the Ain Mreisseh neighborhood, where he lives, he rushed back, only to see a plume of smoke rising from a building behind a mosque across from Beirut’s famous seaside promenade — usually crowded with people walking and exercising.

“The Israeli attack killed my girls, they are innocent, just sitting at home,” al-Jalib said. “They were having lunch.”

He said it took rescue teams three days to extract the bodies of his family from under the rubble. “And I still have a daughter missing, her name is Fatima Hamad al-Jalib.” She is 10 years old. His other daughter was 12 while his sons were 17, 14 and 13 years old.

Three other Syrian relatives were also killed in the Ain Mreisseh strike and were buried on Saturday in the town of al-Shuhail in Deir el-Zour, after the family split upon returning to Syria.

Al-Jalib said his family had been displaced from their area and moved to Lebanon in 2020, as local tensions grew involving tribal groups and the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces.

The casualties from Wednesday’s strikes and others across the country have pushed the death toll in more than a month of Israel’s war with Hezbollah to over 1,950 killed and more than 6,300 wounded, according to Lebanon’s Health Ministry. The toll includes at least 315 Syrians killed and wounded.

It remains unclear how many of those killed on Wednesday were non-Lebanese, as the Health Ministry did not provide a breakdown by nationality. Officials have reported that at least 39 Syrians were among the dead.

Dalal Harb, a spokesperson for the U.N. refugee agency, said the family killed in Ain Mreisseh was not registered with the UNHCR. There are about 530,000 Syrians refugees registered with UNHCR in Lebanon, with hundreds of thousands more believed to be unregistered.

While hundreds of thousands of Syrians have returned from Lebanon since the ouster of former Syrian President Bashar Assad in December 2024, many others remain reluctant to go back because of the lack of jobs and ongoing violence.

Al-Jalib’s brother, Jomaa, who also lived in Lebanon, said he was about 150 meters (500 feet) away at work when the first blast hit. “We ran and we ran, then the second strike happened.” He said he was arriving at the building as it began to collapse. “It was too late to get anyone out. We yelled for them, but no one answered.”

He said ambulances later recovered the bodies, which he identified at a hospital. Following the burial on Saturday, men stood shoulder to shoulder in prayer over the fresh graves.

Govt hikes windfall...

On February 28, the United States and Israel launched military strikes against Iran, triggering sweeping retaliation from Tehran.

On April 8, Iran, the United States and Israel agreed on a two-week ceasefire in the war that tore across the Middle East and disrupted the global energy market. Export duty on petrol continues to remain nil.

MPOST

Asha Bhosle...

been the voice for many leading ladies, from Meena Kumari, Madhubala, Zeenat Aman to Kajol, Urmila Matondkar and also South actors like Padmini and Vijayanthimala. In 2023, she performed at a special concert, ‘ASHA@90: Live in concert’, in Dubai to celebrate her 90th birthday. Bhosle is the younger sister of the legendary singer late Lata Mangeshkar.

AGENCIES

Rare moment: PM...

Though it was not immediately known what they spoke about during their minute-long exchange, Gandhi was seen replying and nodding to Modi on a few occasions.

Gandhi was flanked by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union ministers J P Nadda, Virendra Kumar and Arjun Ram Meghwal, outgoing Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha and newly nominated Rajya Sabha MP Harivansh, among others.

The brief conversation also drew specula-

tion on social media. After paying tributes, Modi wrote on ‘X’: Paid homage to Mahatma Phule in the Parliament complex. May his ideals continue to give strength and hope to countless people.”

Prime Minister Modi described Phule as a visionary social reformer who dedicated his life to the ideals of equality, justice and education.

“He was also a pioneer in championing the rights of women and the marginalised. Through his efforts, education became a powerful instrument of empowerment,” Modi said in another post. The prime minister said this year marks the start of Phule’s 200th birth anniversary celebrations. “May his thoughts continue to guide everyone in the pursuit of societal progress,” he said.

In a post, Gandhi said: “On the birth anniversary of the great social reformer Mahatma Jyotiba Phule ji, I offer my humble homage to him”.

“He dedicated his entire life to protecting the rights and entitlements of the marginalised. His struggle against discrimination and inequality showed the nation the path to equality and justice. “His ideals and thoughts will forever continue to inspire us to move forward towards social justice,” Gandhi said.

Delhi’s EV reset...

delivery and ride aggregator fleets from this year, while only electric auto-rickshaws will be registered starting next year. Additionally, at least 10 per cent of school buses must be electric within two years, with a target of 30 per cent by March 2030. Subsidy on electric three-wheelers and goods carriers

Electric three-wheelers and goods carriers will also receive incentives, including subsidies of up to Rs 50,000 for e-autos in the first year and up to Rs 1 lakh for electric goods vehicles.

Charging infrastructure expansion To support the transition, the government plans a major expansion of EV charging infrastructure, including battery swapping networks. All new public and private construction projects by government bodies will be required to be EV-charging-ready.

With transport emissions contributing nearly half of Delhi’s PM2.5 pollution load—rising to as much as 53 per cent during peak winter months—the policy seeks to directly address one of the city’s largest pollution sources. Experts have welcomed the move, calling it a crucial step toward linking clean air with the right to life.

Implementation will be overseen by an apex committee chaired by the Transport minister, while a high-level panel led by the chief secretary will ensure coordination across departments.

A dedicated digital portal will also be developed to streamline approvals and monitor progress, as the government works toward building a comprehensive EV

ecosystem in the national capital.

India, US to...

“It was a pleasure to host @VikramMisri tonight at Mar a Lago! From trade and defence to energy, India and the United States stand ready to work closely together in the months and years ahead,” Gor posted on social media.

The Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy Act (SHANTI Act) is considered the most sweeping reform in the civil nuclear sector in India.

The law, which came into force last December, opens up the tightly-controlled civil nuclear space for private participation.

It also repealed the Atomic Energy Act of 1962 and the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage (CLND) Act of 2010.

Misri arrived in the US late Tuesday night on a three-day visit.

He has held meetings with senior officials from the departments of defence, commerce and state.

Misri also met Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Thursday.

India’s Air Chief Marshal A P Singh was also on a visit to the US and visited the Peterson Space Force Base in Colorado Springs on Wednesday.

He interacted with General Gregory M Guiltlot (Commander US-NORTHCOM/NORAD) for a productive exchange of perspectives on complex operational modalities, reflecting the strength of the growing partnership, the IAF said in a social media post.

In separate meetings, Gor held discussions with Steve Feinberg, the US Deputy Secretary of Defence and Secretary of the Army Dan Driscoll.

In a social media post, Gor said defence cooperation between the US and India is growing and making both countries safer and stronger.

“Discussed with Deputy Secretary Feinberg ways that we can deepen ties, including through defence sales of US equipment, the best in the world, and strengthening interoperability,” he said.

The US envoy said he discussed the momentum of the US-India relationship since Driscoll’s visit to New Delhi in January.

“Always great to see my friend and Secretary of the Army Dan Driscoll @SecArmy where we discussed the momentum in the US-India relationship following his January visit. The US Army and the Indian Army will play an important role in bolstering defence ties,” Gor said.

He also met Dylan Johnson, the Assistant Secretary of State for Global Public Affairs, and Michael Needham, Counsellor in the Department of State.

AGENCIES

32-HOUR KREMLIN-ANNOUNCED CEASEFIRE UNDERWAY

Ukraine, Russia swap 175 prisoners of war each as ‘Easter truce’ begins

MOSCOW/KYIV: Russia and Ukraine exchanged 175 prisoners of war (PoWs) each as the 32-hour Easter truce announced by the Kremlin began at 4 pm on Saturday.

President Vladimir Putin on Thursday declared the 32-hour ceasefire over the Orthodox Easter weekend. According to his order, Russian forces are to observe the ceasefire starting 4 pm (local time) Saturday till the end of Sunday along the almost 1,300 kms long front in east Ukraine.

Apart from the 175 PoWs exchanged by both sides, Ukraine has also released seven Russian civilians, earlier taken hostage from the western region of Kursk, Russian ombudswoman Tatiana Mas-kalkova told Rossia 24 state TV.

The state TV also added that after more than an hour after its beginning, the truce was holding. However, the Russian



Russian servicemen arrive at an undisclosed location in Belarus during a POW exchange AP

troops have been ordered to be on standby and ready to repulse any “provocation” by the Ukrainian side.

Russian and Ukrainian Orthodox Christians celebrate Easter according to the Julian Calendar, which this year falls on April 12. Since 2003 the St Andrew the First-Called Foundation of Russia has been bring-

ing the Holy Flame from the Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem to Moscow every Easter, TASS reported.

It is delivered to the Easter service in the Moscow Cathedral of Christ the Savior, as well as to other churches across the country.

Russian strikes on Odesa kill 2
Russian drone strikes killed

at least two people in the Ukrainian city of Odesa overnight into Saturday, local authorities reported, ahead of a proposed ceasefire for Orthodox Easter.

A further two people were wounded in the attack on the Black Sea port city, when drones hit a residential area, damaging apartment buildings, houses and a kindergarten.

According to the Ukrainian Air Force, Russia targeted Ukraine with 160 drones overnight, of which 133 were shot down or intercepted, hours before a proposed Easter ceasefire was due to come into force.

Russian officials said 99 Ukrainian drones were shot down overnight across Russia and occupied Crimea. AGENCIES

HIGHLIGHTS

- » ‘Apart from the 175 PoWs exchanged by both sides, Ukraine has also released seven Russian civilians, earlier taken hostage from western region of Kursk’
- » Russian forces observing the ceasefire starting 4 pm Saturday till the end of Sunday along the almost 1,300 kms long front in east Ukraine
- » Russian drone strikes killed at least two people in the Ukrainian city of Odesa overnight into Saturday

Fuel protests rock Ireland

Over third of the country’s service stations run dry

LONDON: Protests over the soaring cost of fuel spread disruption across Ireland on Saturday with many gas stations running dry as truck and tractor drivers staged a fifth day of blockades at the country’s sole fuel refinery and several depots. Vehicles blocking traffic led to closures of the main highway around the capital, Dublin, as well as six other major roadways.

More than a third of the 1,500 service stations in the republic are out of fuel and that number is expected to grow dramatically if the roadblocks remain, Fuels for Ireland chief executive Kevin McPartlan said. Irish police put all its officers on notice they could be called to duty over the weekend and the military was on standby to help remove the vehicles as the government was due to renew talks Saturday to resolve the dispute.

Frustration over the soaring cost of fuel led to the protests that began Tuesday and have continued to grow as word spread on social media.

Officials, who had already introduced measures to ease



A man crosses a road where vehicles are parked, on the second day of a fuel protest against rising fuel prices, in Dublin on Wednesday AP/PTI

the burden of price rises, have been baffled over the rationale behind the protests because the price spike is global and due to the conflict in the Middle East that has restricted oil exports.

Prime Minister Micheál Martin said Friday that the country was on the brink of turning tankers away during a global shortage and was in jeopardy of losing its oil supply.

“It is unconscionable, it’s illogical, it is difficult to comprehend,” Martin told the national broadcaster RTE.

Truckers, farmers, and taxi and bus operators are among those who have staged the blockages and called for caps in fuel prices or cuts to excise or carbon taxes.

The government approved a range of measures two weeks ago to cut fuel prices, including a temporary reduction in excise taxes on motor fuels, expansion of a rebate for truckers and bus operators that use diesel fuel, and extension of a programme that helps low-income people with their heating costs. AGENCIES

France: Boy found locked in his father’s utility van since 2024

‘Malnourished & unable to walk’

PARIS: A 9-year-old boy was rescued this week after living locked in his father’s utility van in eastern France since 2024, according to the local prosecutor. The child has been hospitalised, and his father detained.

Police were alerted by a neighbour to “sounds of a child” coming from a van on Monday in the village of Hagenbach near the borders of Switzerland and Germany, according to a statement from Prosecutor Nicolas Heitz provided Saturday.

After forcing the van open, they found a child “lying in a fetal position, naked, covered by a blanket on top of a mound of trash and near excrement”, the statement said.

The child was clearly malnourished and could no longer walk, because he had been in a seated position for so long, it said.

The boy’s father told investigators that he put the child in the truck in November 2024 “to protect him”, because his partner wanted to send the boy to a psychiatric hospital, the prosecutor said. The boy was 7 at the time.

The prosecutor said there was no medical record that the boy had any psychiatric problems before he disappeared, and that the boy had had good grades in school.

The boy told investigators that he had “big difficulties” with his father’s partner, and thought his father “had no choice” but to lock him up, according to the prosecutor. He said he hadn’t showered since 2024.

The father was handed preliminary kidnapping and other charges and kept in custody. His partner denied knowledge that the boy was in the van, according to the prosecutor. She was handed preliminary charges, including for failure to help a minor in danger, and released under judicial supervision.

‘The boy’s 12-year-old sister and the 10-year-old daughter of his father’s partner were put in the care of social services.

The prosecutor’s office is investigating whether others were aware of the locked-up boy. Friends and family told investigators they thought the boy was in a psychiatric institution. His teachers were told he had transferred to a different school, according to the prosecutor’s office.

Authorities did not release the names of the victim or family members.

Residents of the village expressed shock Saturday at what happened and said they were unaware of the boy’s whereabouts, but didn’t want to discuss details. AGENCIES

France insists on ceasefire in Lebanon

PARIS: French President Emmanuel Macron on Saturday urged “respect for the ceasefire and its application to Lebanon.”

In a social media post, Macron said he talked to Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan on Saturday and that in addition to discussing the ceasefire, they urged a return to free navigation in the Strait of Hormuz. The French leader didn’t mention the negotiations in Pakistan, but said he and Erdogan “underlined the need for a robust and lasting diplomatic solution.”

Macron has been speaking regularly with other world leaders about the war and helping lead efforts for a mission to secure shipping in the Strait of Hormuz once the fighting calms. AGENCIES

China’s state media turns to social media, AI to tell its story, mock US

BEIJING: The messaging from China’s Communist government may once have been dogmatic and rigid — not anymore. Having largely tamed the internet at home with tight censorship, Beijing is now tapping the power of social media and artificial intelligence to tell its story — and often to skewer the US and its president.

In a five-minute AI-generated animation modelled after classic martial arts movies, China’s state media frames an allegory for the war in Iran. A white eagle in regal attire representing the US unleashes an evil laugh before his army attacks a group of Persian cats draped in black cloaks standing in for Iranians, who vow to fight after losing their leader and close off a crucial trading route.

Touching on injustice,



An AI-made animation released by Chinese state media mocking the US as a white eagle is seen on a mobile phone in Beijing AP

revenge and worldly wisdom, the metaphor-rich short is the latest example of several AI-generated animations created by China’s state media in recent months to mock the US as a global bully, including President Donald Trump’s threat to take over Greenland and his plan to exert US predominance in the Western Hemisphere.

The debut use of AI animation comes after Chinese Pres-

ident Xi Jinping has pushed for years to boost the country’s abilities to spread its messages globally, gain a greater say on world affairs and counter Western narratives that Beijing often sees as biased or even derogatory about China. Pro-Iran groups similarly have used sleek, AI-generated memes to taunt the US and Trump.

It’s part of an intensifying global info war in which the US is vowing to up its game to counter foreign anti-American messaging and push back on worldviews against America’s interests. Recent cables by the State Department have warned that foreign messaging campaigns, carried on digital platforms by foreign state-controlled media, “pose a direct threat to US national security and fuel hostility toward American interests.” AGENCIES

Iraq elects Nizar Amidi as Prez amid war fallout

BAGHDAD: Iraq’s parliament voted Saturday to elect Nizar Amidi, a political official with one of the country’s two main Kurdish parties, as president, five months after a parliamentary election that didn’t produce a bloc with a decisive majority.

His election comes as Iraq is reeling from the fallout of the US-Israeli war on Iran. Iraq became caught in the middle of the conflict, with Iran-backed militias launching attacks on US bases and diplomatic facilities as well as on critical energy infrastructure.

Meanwhile, the US and Israel carried out airstrikes targeting the militias, some of which killed members of the Iraqi military.

The war and Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz also largely halted the oil exports upon which Iraq’s economy depends.

Amidi, a member of the political bureau of the Patriotic Union of Kurdistan party, beat out a roster of candidates that included Iraq’s current Foreign Minister, Fuad Hussein, who was the pick of the rival Kurdistan Democratic Party. AGENCIES

Sri Lanka’s elderly population triples in 40 yrs

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka is ageing at a rapid pace, with its elderly population nearly tripled to 18 per cent over the last four decades, according to the latest census data.

As per the 2024 census report released this week by the Department of Census and Statistics, Sri Lanka’s total population stands at 21,781,800, with a national density of 350 persons per square kilometre.

“The elderly population grew from 6.6 per cent in 1981 to 18 per cent by 2024,” the report said.

In 1981, the total elderly population in the island nation was less than a million, which

rose to 3,921,124 by 2024.

The report said the 2024 data “highlight a significant transition toward an ageing society”. The elderly population (60 years and over) now constitutes 18 per cent of the total population, while the child population (0-14 years) has contracted to 20.7 per cent, it said.

“This shift is further evidenced by an Aging Index of 87, indicating that there are 87 elderly persons for every 100 children. Furthermore, the Median Age (35 years) has increased by approximately five years compared to previous census conducted in 2012, reflecting a maturing population structure,” the report said.

In a related trend, the island nation’s total fertility rate (TFR) also declined from 3.3 per cent in 1981 to 1.8 per cent in 2024, the data revealed, underscoring a significant transition towards an ageing society.

The Western province

remains the country’s primary demographic hub, accounting for 28.1 per cent of the total population, it added.

The census also showed that “females outnumber males”, with the national sex ratio at 93.3 males per 100 females.

On the ethnic composition, Sinhalese form 74.1 per cent of the population, followed by Tamils at 12.3 per cent and Muslims at 10.5 per cent.

Buddhism is the predominant religion with 69.8 per cent, followed by Hinduism at 12.6 per cent, Islam at 10.5 per cent, Roman Catholicism at 5.6 per cent, and others at 1.5 per cent, the report said. AGENCIES

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NASA’S ‘RECORD-BREAKING’ LUNAR VOYAGE

Artemis II’s journey ends with dramatic splashdown

HOUSTON: Artemis II’s astronauts closed out humanity’s first lunar voyage in more than half a century with a Pacific splashdown on Friday, blazing new records near the moon with grace and joy.

It was a dramatic grand finale to a mission that revealed not only swaths of the lunar far side never seen before by human eyes, but a total solar eclipse and a parade of planets, most notably our own shimmering Earth against the endless black void of space.

With their flight now complete, the four astronauts have set NASA up for a moon landing by another crew in just two years and a full-blown moon base within the decade.

The triumphant moonfarers — commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Canada’s Jeremy Hansen — emerged from their bobbing capsule into the sunlight off the coast of San Diego.

In a scene reminiscent of NASA’s Apollo moonshots of yesteryear, military helicopters hoisted the astronauts one by one from an inflatable raft docked to the capsule, hauling them aboard for the short trip



Recovery teams secure Orion spacecraft carrying Artemis II crewmembers after splashdown in the Pacific Ocean off coast of California, Friday PTI

to the Navy’s awaiting recovery ship, the USS John P Murtha.

“These were the ambassadors from humanity to the stars that we sent out there right now, and I can’t imagine a better crew,” NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman said from the recovery ship.

NASA’s Mission Control erupted in celebration, with hundreds pouring in from the back support rooms. “We did it,” NASA’s Lori Glaze rejoiced at a news conference. “Welcome to our moonshot.”

Their Orion capsule, dubbed Integrity, made the entire plunge on automatic

pilot. The lunar cruiser hit the atmosphere travelling Mach 33 — or 33 times the speed of sound — a blistering blur not seen since the 1960s and 1970s Apollo.

The tension in Mission Control mounted as the capsule became engulfed in red-hot plasma during peak heating and entered a planned communication blackout. All eyes were on the capsule’s life-protecting heat shield that had to withstand thousands of degrees during reentry.

Watching the drama unfold nearly 3,200 kilometres away, the astronauts’ families huddled in Mission Control’s viewing room, cheering when the capsule emerged from its six-minute blackout and again at splashdown.

The last time NASA and the Defence Department teamed up for a lunar crew’s reentry was Apollo 17 in 1972. Artemis II came screaming back at 36,174 feet (11,026 metres) per second — or 24,664 mph (39,693 kph) — just shy of the record before slowing to a 19 mph (30 kph) splashdown.

Until Artemis II, NASA’s fresh-from-the-moon homecomings starred only white male pilots. Intent on reflect-

ing changes in society, NASA chose a diverse, multinational crew for its lunar comeback.

Koch became the first woman to fly to the moon, Glover the first Black astronaut and Hansen the first non-US citizen, bursting Canada with pride. They laughed, cried and hugged all the way there and back, striving to take the entire world along with them.

Launched from Florida on April 1, the astronauts racked up one win after another as they deftly navigated NASA’s long-awaited lunar comeback, the first major step in establishing a sustainable moon base. AGENCIES

INSIGHT

- » It was a dramatic grand finale to a mission that revealed not only swaths of the lunar far side, but a total solar eclipse and a parade of planets, most notably our own shimmering Earth
- » With their flight now complete, the 4 astronauts have set NASA up for a moon landing by another crew in just 2 years and a full-blown moon base within the decade

UN report: Gap between rich and poor nations growing even ‘wider’

‘Iran war has now darkened outlook for world economy’

UNITED NATIONS: The gap between rich and poor nations is growing even wider as actions agreed to by many countries last year, including overhauling the major global financial institutions, remain unfulfilled promises, a UN report concluded.

The report assessing the blueprint adopted in Seville, Spain, last June to narrow the gap and achieve UN development goals for 2030 was issued ahead of next week’s spring meetings in Washington of the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank, the main global financial institutions promoting economic growth.

The managing director of the IMF, Kristalina Georgieva, said it had been prepared to upgrade global growth, but the Iran war has now darkened the outlook for the world economy.

Li Junhua, the UN under-secretary-general for economic and social affairs, said the geopolitical tensions were compounding the struggles of developing countries to attract financing. “This is an extremely perilous time for international

KEY POINTS

- » ‘The geopolitical tensions were compounding the struggles of developing countries to attract financing’
- » The report pointed to rising trade barriers and repeated climate-related shocks as also adding to growing gap

cooperation, as geopolitical considerations are increasingly shaping economic relations and financial policies,” he said. The report pointed to rising trade barriers and repeated climate-related shocks as also adding to the growing gap.

At last year’s conference in Seville, the leaders of many nations, but not the United States, unanimously adopted the Seville Commitment, which was aimed at closing the USD 4 trillion annual financing gap for development.

It called for scaling up investments in developing countries and reforming the

international financial architecture, including the World Bank and IMF.

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres has repeatedly called for major changes to the two institutions, saying the IMF has benefited rich countries instead of poor ones, and the World Bank has failed in its mission, especially during the Covid-19 pandemic, which left dozens of countries deeply indebted.

His criticisms echo those of outside critics who cite frustration in developing countries with the US and its European allies dominating decision-making at financial institutions.

The UN report on implementing the Seville Commitment said it represents “the best hope” to close the widening financial gap.

But in 2025, Li said 25 countries decreased their development assistance to poorer countries, leading to a 23 per cent overall drop from 2024, the largest annual contraction on record. The biggest decline — 59 per cent — was from the United States, he said. AGENCIES

Kings of the chase

Shreyas-led PBKS chase 200+ again to down Sunrisers Hyderabad

MULLANPUR: Shreyas Iyer once again proved his worth as a leader and a batter, guiding Punjab Kings to a commanding six-wicket victory over Sunrisers Hyderabad in an Indian Premier League match here on Saturday.

After an astute piece of captaincy, Shreyas led by example with an unbeaten 69 off 33 balls to help PBKS chase down a daunting target of 220 with as many as seven balls to spare.

The foundation for the victory was laid by a rollicking 99-run opening stand between Priyansh Arya (57 off 20 balls) and Prabhsimran Singh (51 of 25), after Abhishek Sharma unleashed a brutal onslaught with a blistering 28-ball 74 to power SRH to 219 for six.

Sent in, Abhishek and Travis Head (38 off 23 balls) blew away the PBKS bowlers with a 120-run opening partnership in a mere 8.1 overs.

The home team though made a fine comeback with the ball after Shashank Singh (2/20 in 3 overs) removed both openers in one over and, as a result, SRH, who were 120 for no loss at the start of ninth over, ended inside 220.

Xavier Bartlett (1/42 in 4 overs) bowled a brilliant final over to concede just five runs.

Abhishek smashed eight



PBKS' captain Shreyas Iyer scored an unbeaten 69 off 33 balls

PTI

sixes and five fours.

In reply, PBKS got the start they needed and raced to 93 for no loss in the powerplay, with the opening duo of Priyansh and Prabhsimran going hammer and tongs at the SRH bowlers. Left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey leaked 18 runs in the first over, providing PBKS with the perfect launch pad.

Prabhsimran danced down the ground to get a couple of sixes, including one against veteran left-arm seamer Jaydev Unadkat, even as Eshan Mal-

inga gave away 17 runs.

Priyansh then hammered Harshal Patel for 6, 6, 4, 4 to race to a 16-ball fifty.

Shivang Kumar raised SRH hopes by picking three wickets but Shreyas completed the job for his side.

Earlier, Abhishek got off the blocks quickly and launched into Arshdeep to collect 24 runs with the help of two fours and two maximums including a straight six and another off a top edge over third man.

Marco Jansen, too, was

taken to the cleaners with 16 runs in the left-arm quick's first over as SRH reached 60 for no loss in four overs.

Abhishek reached his half-century in 18 balls with a six over long-on off a Vyshak Vijaykumar slower ball, and two balls later, a low full toss was lofted over long-on for another maximum to signal the end of another 24-run over, which propelled SRH to 84 for no loss in five overs, the best powerplay score at this venue.

AGENCIES

MI seek home comfort vs RCB

MUMBAI: Back in familiar territory after yet another slow start to their Indian Premier League campaign, Mumbai Indians will be keen to make the most of their return to home turf when they take on defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru here on Sunday.

For the first time in 13 seasons, MI made a winning start to an IPL season when they defeated Kolkata Knight Riders by six wickets here at the Wankhede Stadium nearly two weeks ago.

But the five-time title winners failed to build on it, as they lost both their away fixtures by big margins and are now languishing in eighth place with a poor Net Run Rate (-0.715). Even as Rohit Sharma briefly held the Orange Cap, batting remains a concern for MI and a collective show would be the need of the hour.

AGENCIES

NINGBO: India's Ayush Shetty stormed into the final with a stunning three-game win over top seed and defending champion Kunlavut Vitidsarn, assuring himself of at least a silver medal at the Badminton Asia Championships here on Saturday.

The world No. 25 rode on his superior attack and robust defence to script a sensational 10-21 21-19 21-17 comeback win over Thailand's Vitidsarn, the Paris Olympics silver medallist and 2023 world champion, in the semifinal that lasted 75 minutes.

"Ayush handled the situation well. He seemed to get into Kunlavut's head with his attacking style and exploited that smartly," Vimal Kumar, former India chief coach and Director of Centre for Badminton Excellence (Formerly PPBA), said.

"Taking the second game was crucial. At 20-14, Ayush Shetty looked in control but got a bit anxious as Vitidsarn clawed back to 20-19. That is where he produced something special to close it out. All week, he has shown an ability to respond in tight moments, using the right tactics and deploying his smashes and clips judiciously."



Ayush Shetty beat Kunlavut Vitidsarn in three games

BAC

1

Ayush became the first Indian men's singles player after Dinesh Khanna to reach the final

With the win, Ayush became the first Indian men's singles player after Dinesh Khanna to reach the finals of the prestigious tournament.

Khanna remains the only

Indian to win the men's singles gold at the continental meet way back in 1965. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty won the doubles title in 2023.

The Indian has secured several high-profile scalps on the BWF World Tour, including

Paris bronze winner Lee Zii Jia, former world champion Loh Kean Yew and Brain Yang. This week, Ayush knocked out world No. 7 Li Shi Feng and world No. 4 Jonatan Christie before outwitting Vitidsarn.

"What he needed was maturity. That showed here. He played composed, intelligent badminton," Vimal said. "At just 20, he has time on his side. India now has two strong men's singles players."

AGENCIES

TOO MATURE FOR 15-YR-OLD Sooryavanshi coming of age, feels RCB's Bhuvu



RR's Vaibhav Sooryavanshi made a stunning 78 in their win over RCB

PTI

GUWAHATI: Sooryavanshi blazed his way to a stunning 78 off just 26 balls before Dhruv Jurel anchored the chase with an unbeaten 81, as Rajasthan Royals put past defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru by six wickets and two overs to spare, stretching their unbeaten run to four matches this season.

"The way he is hitting shots. He is not sloggng, he is hitting proper shots. For a 15-year-old, he is too mature. So yes, I think we should give him credit for the way he is batting, and he is batting really well. So he deserves all the credit," Bhuvneshwar Kumar said at the post-match press conference on Friday.

Despite Sooryavanshi's onslaught, which included eight fours and seven sixes, Bhuvneshwar maintained that RCB never felt completely outplayed. "It's a T20 game, I mean. Yes, he is young, and he is batting very well. He is batting maturely, but we never felt that somebody was thrashing us. If a 15-year-old can bat like this, even if he is 25 or 15, I think it's part of the T20 game. Yes, we had plans, we dropped a catch too, but that happens in cricket. So we couldn't execute what we wanted to do, and

“The way he is hitting shots. He is not sloggng, he is hitting proper shots. For a 15-year-old, he is too mature.”
— Bhuvneshwar Kumar

I think it is a part of T20, so we are not worried that much," said Bhuvneshwar.

"We tried what we could do. I know that from the outside, the game looks a little slow compared to how it looks inside. Vaibhav played good shots. So I think we felt that we couldn't do anything different."

Forced to bolster their batting in pursuit of a competitive total, RCB brought in all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer in place of the originally intended leg-spinner Suyash Sharma, a move that eventually hampered their bowling flexibility.

"It is difficult to use spinners in powerplay, and we had only one left-arm spinner, as we used an Impact instead of Suyash."

AGENCIES

Animesh picks up 100m title in photo finish

NEW DELHI: Star sprinter Animesh Kujur of Odisha won the 100m dash in a photo finish after earlier clinching the 200m title, running away with the spotlight at the one-day Indian Athletics Series here on Saturday.

Opening his outdoor season on the 'fast' Mondo track, Kujur won the 200m race in the morning session with a time of 20.74 seconds, beating 400m national record holder Vishal T who ran 21.01 seconds. Vishal was representing NCOE Trivandrum.

Dharamveer Choudhary of Rajasthan clocked the third best time of 21.03 seconds. More than 50 athletes competed in the men's 200m race.

The 22-year-old Kujur was, however, pushed to the limit by Tamil Arasu of Railways in the 100m dash as both were initially given identical time of 10.28 seconds. Later, the photo finish was decided in favour of Kujur, who clocked 10.272 seconds compared to Arasu's 10.280. Gurvindervir Singh, who won the 60m gold in the National Indoor Championships last month in Bhubaneswar where Kujur was disqualified for a false start, finished third.

AGENCIES

Vaishali's dream run continues at Candidates, outplays Goryachkina

PAPHOS: Indian Grandmaster R Vaishali continued her remarkable run and defeated Aleksandra Goryachkina of Russia in the 11th round of the Women's Candidates tournament here on Saturday.

With her fourth victory in the event, Vaishali took her tally to an impressive seven points from 11 games. For Russian Goryachkina, the loss virtually ended her chances in the event as she remained on five points, two adrift of the tournament leader.

Vaishali's victory also ensured that she stretched her lead by a full point over nearest rivals Anna Muzychuk of Ukraine and Jiner Zhu of China who were both held to draws by Kateryna Lagno of Russia and Divya Deshmukh respectively.

Playing white, Goryachkina surprisingly employed the London system in this key game and Vaishali played nonchalantly in the opening to get close to an equal position in the early middle game.

The Russian wanted to complicate matters after an early exchange of Queens but Vaishali proved she was far ahead in the calculation on this day as she matched Goryachkina move for move and pounced on a creative idea that entailed



R Vaishali took her tally to seven points from 11 games

FIDE

Vaishali's victory also ensured that she stretched her lead by a full point over nearest rivals

trapping of white's rook right in the middle of the board.

Vaishali lost just one pawn and a minor piece in the bargain and in the resulting position her technique was immaculate to romp home.

It may be recalled that Vaishali started off very slowly in the event drawing the first four games followed by a loss against Jiner Zhu of China but since the sixth round has scored as many as four wins and two

draws which also means she is peaking at the right time.

In the open section, Vaishali's younger brother R Praggnanandhaa continued to struggle as he missed out on a simple tactic to score a victory over Matthias Bluebaum of Germany.

Hikaru Nakamura of United States played out a draw with Wei Yi of China with both conceding that they were out of the race while Dutchman Anish Giri also played out a draw with Andrey Esipenko of Russia. Tournament leader by almost a mile, Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan was still fighting it out against Fabiano Caruana of United States in what looked like a drawable endgame.

AGENCIES

BKJC: Ankita's defeat ends India's World Group playoffs hopes

NEW DELHI: A fearless Vaishnavi Adkar rose to the occasion with an inspiring win over higher-ranked Sohyun Park, leading India to a 2-1 win over South Korea after Ankita Raina's defeat to Dayeon Back ended the hosts' hopes of making the Billie Jean King Cup World Group Play-offs, here on Saturday. Placed fourth in the standings at the start of the day, India needed a 3-0 sweep against Korea to stay in contention for a top-two finish. Captain Vishal Uppal fielded his most experienced campaigner Ankita in the opening singles, but Dayeon quelled the home challenge, handing India a setback.

The 33-year-old Ankita, ranked 581, fought hard after a slow start against the 343rd-ranked Korean but eventually went down 1-6 5-7 in one hour and 55 minutes. She had not featured in singles prior to this tie, having played only doubles in the tournament.

India's No. 1 Vaishnavi then kept the contest alive, producing a gritty 7-6(2) 7-6(5) win over Park, who is ranked 107 places above her at 276.

Vaishnavi had an impressive run at the W100 event



Ankita raina in action against South Korea

PTI

recently in Bengaluru, where she beat two top-130 players and followed that up with a title win in the W35 tournament in Kalaburagi. Ankita and Rutuja Bhosale concluded India's campaign with a 6-2 6-2 win against Dayeon Back and Eunhye Lee in the tie-deciding doubles rubber.

With a third-place finish, India stayed in the Asia/Oceania Group I along with fourth-placed Korea. Thailand and Indonesia qualified for the World Group Play-offs after finishing one and two respectively. New Zealand and Mongolia were relegated to Group II.

AGENCIES

Dempo SC drill three past Aizawl FC in IFL

MARGAO: Dempo SC notched up an easy 3-0 win over Aizawl FC to secure their second consecutive victory in Indian Football League here on Saturday.

Marcus Joseph (43rd), Jose Luis Moreno (53rd) and Sebastian Gutierrez (90th+) scored the goals for Dempo.

Dempo SC moved ahead of their opponents to fifth in the table with nine points from nine matches, while Aizawl dropped to sixth in the table with the same number of points.

Aizawl FC looked the better side in the first half, showing clear attacking intent and keeping the Dempo defence busy.

Ashish Siby was the busier of the two goalkeepers, making multiple interventions inside the box, including a sharp save to deny Lalitanzova's effort from distance. K Vanlalhrizuala also had a chance from the edge of the box but failed to keep his shot down.

At the other end, Dempo SC were patient in their build-up, looking to play out from the back, but struggled to create clear openings for their front pair of Marcus Joseph and Richmond Owusu.

The only time the opposition goalkeeper was tested came from Saiesh Bagkar, whose long-range effort was on target. The home side took

Dempo SC moved ahead of their opponents to fifth in the table with nine points

the lead just before the break against the run of play. H. Lalrempuia failed to deal with a pass from midfield, and Kapil Hoble capitalised on the error to deliver an inviting cross into the box that found Saiesh.

The full-back controlled it well, beat his marker, and aimed a shot towards the bottom corner. The goalkeeper, who appeared to have it covered, was wrong-footed as the ball took a wicked deflection off Marcus Joseph and ended up in the back of the net.

Dempo carried their momentum into the second half, creating two goalscoring opportunities within five minutes of the restart. Aubin Kouakou was unable to keep his header on target from a corner, while Marcus, left in acres of space inside the box, also failed to hit the target.

The home side then doubled their advantage in the 53rd minute from a corner kick. Kapil Hoble's delivery was powerfully met by Saiesh Bagkar, forcing an acrobatic save from Aizawl goalkeeper.

AGENCIES

CISF's Abhimanyou, clinches gold

BISHKEK: World U23 champion Sujeet and Abhimanyou registered contrasting victories in their respective men's freestyle final bouts to help India clinch two gold medals on the penultimate day of the Senior Asian Wrestling Championships here on Saturday.

Sujeet, who has been unbeaten so far this year, totally dominated the men's 65kg freestyle final against Umidjon Jalolov of Uzbekistan to register an 8-1 win and become the first Indian since Bajrang Punia's 2019 triumph to win the Asian Championships gold medal in this weight category.

Sujeet started slow in the opening round as Jalolov held his ground and did not allow the Indian to attack. But the 23-year-old India was quick off the blocks at the start of the second round and went on to register his fifth victory over the Uzbek wrestler.

A few minutes later, Abhimanyou made it a double celebration for the Indian camp as he fought back from 0-2 deficit to beat Tulga Tumur Ochir of Mongolia 5-3 in the men's 70kg freestyle final.

Sandeep Mann had the chance to complete a hat-trick of gold medals for India but he went down 1-2 in a closely contested final bout in the men's 79kg category.

MPOST

Arsenal's loss opens door for City in title race; Bellingham returns but Real lose

LONDON: Arsenal's Premier League title bid was hit by a stunning 2-1 loss to Bournemouth at home on Saturday.

The league leaders blew the chance to move 12 points clear of second-place Manchester City after losing for the third time in four games in all competitions.

Alex Scott struck a 74th-minute winner at the Emirates to pile pressure on Arsenal ahead of next week's top-of-the-table clash at City.

Mikel Arteta's team has played two more games than City, which could close the gap to six points if they beat Chelsea on Sunday at Stamford Bridge.

Arsenal's form appears to be slipping at a crucial point of the season. Defeats to City in the English League Cup final and second-division Southampton

Gunners now a marked team



Bournemouth's Alex Scott scores the winner against Arsenal

AP

in the FA Cup ended their pursuit of a quadruple of trophies.

They won 1-0 in the Champions League against Sporting Lisbon on Tuesday, but the

latest loss will only heighten tension in the race for the title after three straight years of finishing runner-up in England's top flight.

As so often this season, Madrid were unable to convert pressure into chances and they were suspect at the back again

Real Madrid held MADRID: Jude Bellingham's first start since February 1 was not enough to spark a Real Madrid revival as they drew with Girona 1-1 and missed a chance to put pressure on La Liga leader Barcelona.

Bellingham was with-

drawn after 10 minutes in a game against Rayo Vallecano and subsequently missed nine club matches, including the twin victories over Manchester City that took Real Madrid into the Champions League quarterfinals.

He made three substitute appearances in Madrid's previous three games but started against Girona in a fixture the home side needed to win to cut into Barcelona's seven-point lead.

Instead, Madrid ended the night ruing missed opportunities.

Federico Valverde put Madrid 1-0 up six minutes into the second half when the Girona goalkeeper allowed his long-range shot to squirm through his hands. But visiting Girona wasted no time in levelling the scores.

AGENCIES

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the Newspapers, social media platforms& website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS
*Name of the Election: : GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026
Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

- (1) Name of the Constituency - 82 – Chapra Assembly Constituency
(2) Name of the candidate – – Jeber Sekh

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1. Sections 341/323/325/506/34 of the Indian penal Code, 1860.
	b.	Case no.	1. G.R Case No. 769/2018, arising out of P.S. Case No. 82/2018, dated – 23.04.2018, Chapra Police Station.
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned Judicial Magistrate 2nd Court, Krishnagar, Nadia.
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. Yes, on 24.06.2024
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is a well-known and veteran public figure with a strong presence in his electorate where he has consistently and untiringly put in efforts for amplifying the voices of underprivileged and marginalized groups. His relatability and dedication to public service make a strong case for his legislative candidacy.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

- (3) Name of the Constituency – 82 – Chapra Assembly Constituency
(4) Name of the candidate: Jeber Sekh

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.
Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O’Brien
Member, National Working Committee,
All India Trinamool Congress

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the Newspapers, social media platforms& website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS
*Name of the Election: : GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026
Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

- (1) Name of the Constituency - 51 – English Bazar Assembly Constituency
(2) Name of the candidate – Asis Kundu

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences Alleged Under: Section 427 I.P.C r/w Section 3(2)(a) of P.D.P.P Act
	b.	Case no.	G.R. No. 543/2007(arising out of P.S Case No. 103/2007 dated 16.03.2007, English Bazar Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	Learned Chief Judicial Magistrate Court, Malda
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	N/A
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	N/A
	g.	Any other information required to be given	N/A
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate brings an understanding of grassroots concern and socio-economic challenges. His selection is based on his qualifications and ability to represent constituents effectively in legislative matters, in line with principles of merit and public service.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

- (3) Name of the Constituency – 51 – English Bazar Assembly Constituency
(4) Name of the candidate: Asis Kundu

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.
Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O’Brien
Member, National Working Committee,
All India Trinamool Congress

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the Newspapers, social media platforms& website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS
*Name of the Election: : GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026
Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

- (1) Name of the Constituency - 224-Kharagpur Sadar Assembly Constituency
(2) Name of the candidate – Pradip Sarkar

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences Alleged Under Sections: 1.Under Sections 147/146/145 of Railway Act 2.Under Section 146/145 of Railway Act 3.Under Sections 147/146/145 of Railway Act
	b.	Case no.	1. FIR No. 91/2025, RPF Town Post Kgp. 2. FIR No. 86/2025, RPF Town Post Kgp. 3. FIR No. 18/2025, RPF Town Post Kgp.
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned Judicial Magistrate, Railway Court at Kharagpur. 2. Learned Judicial Magistrate, Railway Court at Kharagpur 3.Learned Judicial Magistrate, Railway Court at Kharagpur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No

	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is dedicated to the welfare of the society and has been actively involved in addressing local issues within the constituency. He demonstrates a sound understanding of governance processes and community needs, along with the ability to effectively articulate and represent public concerns. His selection reflects his commitment to public service and his capacity to make a constructive contribution to legislative work.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

- (3) Name of the Constituency – 224-Kharagpur Sadar Assembly Constituency
(4) Name of the candidate: Pradip Sarkar

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O’Brien
Member, National Working Committee,
All India Trinamool Congress

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sahil @ Gajnumi @ Kajnumi, S/o Abdul Salam R/o H.No.554/15, Amir Khuroo Nagar, Basti, Hazrat Nizamuddin** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.64/2021 Dated 08.03.2021 u/s 324/307/308/34 IPC, P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sahil @ Gajnumi @ Kajnumi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sahil @ Gajnumi @ Kajnumi** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sahil @ Gajnumi @ Kajnumi** of **FIR No.64/2021 Dated 08.03.2021 u/s 324/307/308/34 IPC, P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** is required to appear before me before me to answer the said complaint on or before **14.05.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Manuj Kaushal

Ld. Judicial Magistrate First-03, South-East
Room No.512, Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/4643/SE/2026



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for and on behalf to President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (e-Tendering) for the following work:

Tender No. : AGCTRD202608	Approximate Cost : Rs. 50,91,167.50/-
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Name of work : Modification in OHE due to "Provision of Cross Over at MTJ end between 3rd & 4th Line"

Earnest Money : Rs. 1,01,800.00/-	Period of completion : Twelve months
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1. For full details & submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.iraps.gov.in 2. Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.iraps.gov.in up to 15:30 Hrs on date 04.05.2026 785/26 (C)

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 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in
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**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING
THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

(SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Rohit Sekh S/o Samim Sekh R/o Jhuggi No. 202, Behind Surya Hotel, Rithala, Delhi** committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. **541/2019 U/s 224 IPC, PS Shahbad Dairy, Distt. Outer North, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Rohit Sekh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Rohit Sekh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation are hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Rohit Sekh** of FIR No. **541/2019 U/s 224 IPC, PS Shahbad Dairy, Distt. Outer North, Delhi** are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **29.05.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order
Sh. Sarthak Panwar
JM First Class-05 (North)
Courts No. 114, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/4535/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Anil Singh @ Lalu** S/o. **Rajesh Singh Chhote Singh**, R/o.: **Village Rooppur, P.S. Bela, District Auraiya, Uttar Pradesh** Also at: **E-73, B-120, Sanjay Colony, Gokul Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **FIR No. 102/2024 U/S 365/302/201/34 IPC** registered at **P.S Jyoti Nagar, North East District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said **Anil Singh @ Lalu** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Anil Singh @ Lalu** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Anil Singh @ Lalu**, accused of **FIR No. 102/2024 U/S 365/302/201/34 IPC, P.S Jyoti Nagar, North East District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.06.2026**.

By Order, Rahul Saini,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06,
Room No. G-06, New Court Building, Shahdara,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi.

DP/4658/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

(See Section 82 C. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Rahul @Murga** S/o Harbuns @Harbans @Pintu R/o H. No. 261, Gali No. 5, Shiv Vihar, Rishal Garden, Nangloi, Najafgarh Road, Nihal Vihar, Chander Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 1301/2024 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS ACT, PS Nihal Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Rahul @Murga** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rahul @Murga** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Rahul @Murga** in **FIR No. 1301/2024 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS ACT, PS Nihal Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.05.2026**.

By order
Ms Komal Garg
Metropolitan Magistrate-03
West District, Room No. 292
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/4701/OD/2026

04226/04225 Varanasi Jn. - LokmanyaTilak (T) - Varanasi Jn. Reserved Special Express Train (Weekly)				16 Trips	
TRAIN NO. 04226		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 04225		
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.	
—	01:35		Varanasi Jn.	02:05	—
06:20	06:30		Lucknow	20:50	21:00
12:20	—	Lokmanya Tilak (T)	—	14:35	
Days of Run : 04226 Ex. Varanasi Jn. from 21.05.2026 to 09.07.2026 (every Thursday) and 04225 Ex. Lokmanya Tilak (T) from 22.05.2026 to 10.07.2026 (every Friday)					
Stoppages : Jaunpur City, Sultanpur, Lucknow, Kanpur Central, Orai, Virangana Lakshimbai Jhansi, Bina, Rani Kamlapati, Itarsi Jn, Khandwa, Bhusaval, Pachora Jn, Chalisgaon Jn, Nasik Road, Igatpur, Kalyan and Thane stations.					
Accommodation : 3 Tier AC Economy & General.					
04070/04069 Anand Vihar (T) - Sheikhpura - Anand Vihar (T) Reserved Special Express Train (Bi-Weekly)				52 Trips	
TRAIN NO. 04070		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 04069		
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.	
—	00:20		Anand Vihar (T)	23:20	—
23:30	—		Sheikhpura	—	00:30
Days of Run : 04070 Ex. Anand Vihar (T) from 17.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (every Friday & Tuesday) and 04069 Ex. Sheikhpura from 18.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (every Saturday & Wednesday)					
Stoppages : Govindpur, Prayagraj Jn., Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn., Dildar Nagar Jn., Buxar, Raghu Nathpur, Ara, Danapur, Patna Jn., Rejnendra Nagar Terminal, Bakhtiyarpur Jn., Bihar Sharif Jn. and Asthawan stations.					
Accommodation : 1st AC, AC 2 Tier & AC 3 Tier.					

04185/04186 Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi - Asansol - 46				
Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi Special Train (Bi-Weekly) Trips				
TRAIN NO. 04185		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 04186	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	09:20	Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi	19:10	—
20:45	20:50	Varanasi Jn.	06:35	06:40
14:30	—	Asansol	—	17:10
Days of Run : 04185 Ex. Virangana Lakshmbai Jhansi upto 28.06.2026 (every Sunday & Wednesday) and 04186 Ex. Asansol upto 29.06.2026 (every Monday & Thursday)				
Stoppages : Orai, Pokhrayan, Govindpuri, Fatehpur, Prayagraj Jn., Gyanpur Road, Banaras, Varanasi Jn., Aunrihar Jn., Ghazipur City, Ballia, Surainampur, Chhapra, Hajipur, Shahpur Patoree, Barauni, Kiul Jn., Hajhaja, Jasidih, Madhupur Jn. and Chittaranjan stations.				
Accommodation : AC 3 Tier, Sleeper, Second Sitting & General.				
04127/04128 Kanpur Central - Guwahati - Kanpur Central Special Train (Weekly)				10 Trips
TRAIN NO. 04127		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 04128	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	08:00	Kanpur Central	07:30	—
13:45	13:50	Varanasi Jn.	23:05	23:15
19:00	—	Guwahati	—	22:00

09523/09524 Okha - Shakur Basti - Okha Superfast Special Train (Weekly)				24 Trips
TRAIN NO. 09523		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 09524	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	10:20	Okha	17:30	—
10:35	—	Shakur Basti	—	13:15
Days of Run : 09523 Ex. Okha from 14.04.26 to 30.06.26 (every Tuesday) and 09524 Ex. Shakur Basti from 15.04.26 to 01.07.26 (every Wednesday)				
Stoppages : Dwarka, Khambhalia, Jamnagar, Hapa, Rajkot Jn., Wankaner, Surendra Nagar, Viramgam Jn., Mahesana Jn., Unjha, Siddhpur, Palanpur Jn., Abu Road, Falna, Marwar Jn., Beawar, Ajmer, Kishangarh, Jaipur, Gandhinagar Jaipur, Dausa, Bandikui, Alwar, Rewari, Gurgaon and Delhi Cantt stations.				
Accommodation : AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, 3 Tier AC Economy, Sleeper & General.				
04086/04085 Meerut City Jn. - Santragachi Jn. - Meerut City Jn. Reserved Special Express Train				02 Trips
TRAIN NO. 04086		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 04085	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	23:00	Meerut City Jn.	17:30	—
06:35	—	Santragachi Jn	—	14:00
Days of Run : 04086 Ex. Meerut City Jn. on 14.04.2026 and 04085 Ex. Santragachi Jn. on 16.04.2026				
Stoppages : Hapur Jn., Khurja Jn., Aligarh Jn., Govindpuri, Subedarganj, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn., Bhabua Road, Sasaram, Dehri On Sone, Anugrah Narayan Road, Gaya Jn., Paharpur, Koderma, Hazaribagh Road, Parasnath, Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Jn. Gomoh, Mahuda Jn., Bhojudih Jn., Adra, Bankura, Bishnupur, Midnapore, Kharagpur and Panskura stations.				
Accommodation : AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.				

09195/09196 Pratap Nagar - Mau Jn. -				31
Pratap Nagar Superfast Special Train (Weekly)				Trips
TRAIN NO. 09195		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 09196	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	16:00	Pratap Nagar	03:15	—
15:40	15:45	Varanasi	02:15	02:20
18:00	—	Mau Jn.	—	23:25
Days of Run : 09195 Ex. Pratap Nagar upto 25.07.26 (every Saturday) and 09196 Ex. Mau Jn. from 12.04.26 to 26.07.26 (every Sunday)				
Stoppages : Vadodra Jn., Godhra, Dahod, Ratlam Jn., Kota Jn., Gangapur City, Bayana Jn., Rupbas, Agra cantt, Fatehabad, Bah. Etawah, Govindpuri, Prayagraj Jn., Gyanpur Road, Banaras, Varanasi and Aunrihar Jn. stations.				
Accommodation : 1st AC, AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.				
09271/09272 Bhavnagar (T) - Haridwar -				16
Bhavnagar (T) Special Train on Special Fare (Weekly)				Trips
TRAIN NO. 09271		STATIONS	TRAIN NO. 09272	
ARR.	DEP.		ARR.	DEP.
—	04:25	Bhavnagar (T)	04:35	—
15:00	—	Haridwar	—	16:25
Days of Run : 09271 Ex. Bhavnagar (T) from 12.04.26 to 31.05.26 (every Sunday) and 09272 Ex. Haridwar from 13.04.26 to 01.06.26 (every Monday)				
Stoppages : Sihor Gujarat, Dhola Jn., Botad Jn., Surendranagar Gate, Viramgam Jn., Ambli Road, Gandhinagar Capital, Mahesana Jn, Palanpur Jn., Abu Road, Pindwara, Falna, Marwar Jn., Pall Marwar Jn., Jodhpur Jn., Gotan, Merta Road Jn., Degana Jn., Chhoti Khatu, Didwana, Ladnun, Sujangarh, Ratangarh Jn., Churu, Sadulpur Jn., Siwani, Hisar, Bhiwani Jn., Kalanaur Kalan, Rohtak Jn., Panipat Jn., Ambala Cant Jn., Saharanpur Jn. and Roorkee stations.				
Accommodation : AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.				

For any kind of information, passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

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With over a million displaced, Lebanon faces a spiralling humanitarian emergency as intensified Israeli offensives force civilians from homes, collapsing fragile ceasefire hopes and pushing already strained communities toward deeper instability and uncertainty

LEBANON IS ONCE AGAIN WEST ASIA'S EXPOSED NERVE, AS CEASEFIRE HOPES COLLAPSE AND ISRAELI STRIKES TRIGGER THE DEADLIEST PHASE OF THE CONFLICT

LEBANON

Once Again the Battlefield

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

April 9 witnessed the deadliest day of the current Israeli military attack on Lebanon, which killed over 300 people. Israel launched a barrage of strikes on Lebanon on Wednesday despite the ceasefire, a sudden intensification of a campaign it says is directed at the Tehran-backed militant group Hezbollah. Israel's assault on Lebanon had already killed nearly 2,000 people and displaced more than a million. Now it threatens the collapse of the U.S.-Iran ceasefire that had raised hopes across the Middle East. Just hours after US President Donald Trump had announced that a two-week ceasefire had been agreed to halt the war in the Middle East, Israeli jets conducted a 10-minute blitz across Lebanon.

Israel, which occupied southern Lebanon for around two decades until 2000, has intensified strikes across Lebanon and sent ground troops into the country's south since the latest bout of fighting began. Lebanon was pulled into the Middle East war when Hezbollah began firing rockets into Israel on March 2 to avenge the killing of Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. The Houthis, who control most of northern Yemen, joined the war in support of Iran on March 28. The three allies "launched a barrage of cruise missiles and drones targeting several vital and military sites belonging to the Israeli enemy". Benjamin Netanyahu has said

there is "no ceasefire in Lebanon" and Israel would continue "to strike Hezbollah with full force" as the country's military launched fresh strikes. In a written message, Iran's new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, said the Islamic Republic did not want war with the US and Israel, but would protect its rights as a nation. In an apparent reference to Lebanon, he said, "We did not seek war, and we do not want it," he said. "But we will not renounce our legitimate rights under any circumstances, and in this respect, we consider the entire resistance front as a whole". Pakistan, which accelerated its mediation efforts after Trump threatened a civilisation-ending onslaught, has said Lebanon had been part of the agreement. The US vice-president, JD Vance, assigned to lead the US delegation to peace talks in Pakistan, suggested there had been a "legitimate misunderstanding" on the geographic reach of the ceasefire deal.

Iran warned that, in response to the Israeli attacks after the ceasefire, it would once more close the Strait of Hormuz, the economically critical waterway it had agreed to open for the two-week duration of the ceasefire. The country's president, Masoud Pezeshkian, said negotiations were "meaningless" as long as Israel continued to bomb Lebanon, placing in doubt US-Iranian talks in Pakistan scheduled for Saturday. Pezeshkian vowed Iran would not abandon the Lebanese people.

Global leaders denounced the Thursday attacks and demanded that Lebanon be included in the ceasefire. It is "hard to argue" the strikes were carried out in self-defence, European Union foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas said on X, while French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot said the attacks were "intolerable" and stressed that "Lebanon must absolutely be covered by this truce".

Ahead of the US-Iran peace talks in Islamabad, Israel's ambassador to India, Reuven Azar, expressed deep scepticism toward Pakistan, stating that Israel does not trust the country and suggesting that the United States shares this view, merely treating Pakistan's role in the process as



logistical facilitation. In a sharp and unprecedented escalation, Pakistan's Defence Minister Khawaja Asif on Thursday called Israel "evil" and a "curse for humanity" for attacking Lebanon amid a US-Iran ceasefire, drawing a strong rebuttal from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. In a now-deleted post on X, Asif claimed that "peace talks are underway in Islamabad, genocide is being committed in Lebanon".

LEBANON'S TROUBLED HISTORY

Lebanon's history has been defined especially by its prolific ports along the Mediterranean trade routes. The refuge in its mountainous terrain has offered to groups fleeing persecution, and, since the Middle Ages, it has offered religious diversity. Phoenicians- persons who inhabited one of the city-states of ancient Phoenicia, such as Byblos, Sidon, Tyre, or Beirut, were the natives of Lebanon. Located along eastern Mediterranean trade routes, the Phoenician city-states produced notable merchants, traders, and colonisers. By the 2nd millennium BCE, they had settled in the Levant, North Africa, Anatolia, and Cyprus. Lebanon has been an important commercial hub for the Middle East. It has also often been at the centre of Middle Eastern conflicts, despite its small size, because of its borders with Syria and Israel and its uniquely complex communal make-up.

Since the 7th century, Lebanon has served as a refuge for persecuted Christian and Muslim groups. Lebanon as a contemporary state did not come into being until August 1920, when France established the state of Greater Lebanon as part of its League of Nations mandate. "Greater Lebanon," with its current borders, was established by the French colonial regime governing Lebanon and modern-day Syria. Before World War I, Lebanon was part of the Ottoman Empire. The Ottomans ran their Empire. The Ottoman Empire included Muslim, Christian, and Jewish

THE GREATER ISRAEL CLAIM EMERGES AGAIN, SHAPING INTERPRETATIONS OF ISRAEL'S EXPANDING MILITARY FOOTPRINT IN LEBANON

communities. In the Mount Lebanon area (which is much smaller than contemporary Lebanon), Christian Maronite and Druze (a small subset of Shia Islam) communities lived in close proximity and relative harmony. This, however, started to change with the expansion of British and French imperialism into the Eastern Mediterranean during the 19th century.

The Republic of Lebanon (1943) — an Arabic-speaking country in Western Asia, is bordered by Syria to the north and east, and Israel to the south. Widely known as the "Switzerland of the East", Lebanon attracted large numbers of tourists and its capital, Beirut — a major port city on the Mediterranean, became commonly referred to as the "Paris of the East".

Political analysts argue that Lebanon's religious and ethnic diversities have complicated the development of a stable political arrangement and impeded the development of a single national identity. Lebanon is a parliamentary democratic republic, which implements a special system known as confessionalism — a type of consociationalism which functions durably despite major internal divisions along ethnic, religious, or linguistic lines in which no sub-group commands a majority.

Lebanon is a confessional state where, for example, positions in cabinet, parliament, the civil service, and other institutions



are apportioned according to the relative religious populations. About 60 per cent of the Lebanese are Muslim and the rest are Christians. There are six different Muslim sects (in numeric order: Shi'a, Sunni, Druze, Isma'ili, Alawite or Nusayri), and twelve different Christian sects (in numeric order: Maronite Catholic, Greek Orthodox, Melkite Catholic, Armenian Orthodox, Syrian Catholic, Armenian Catholic, Syrian Orthodox, Roman Catholic, Chaldean, Assyrian, Copt, Protestant) These sects are largely geographically defined. This mosaic of peoples and politics has led the Lebanese to historically seek a balance of power through a political arrangement known as confessionalism.

Most scholars agree that various forms of confessionalism existed in Lebanon as early as the 13th century and later in various forms under Ottoman rule. Encouraged by the Maronite community, the French formed "Greater Lebanon" by melding the old province of Lebanon (i.e. Mont-Liban, largely Maronite) with the coastal regions of Beirut, Sidon, Tyre, and Tripoli, as well as the Bekaa Valley (largely Muslim) The Lebanese Muslims and Syria, however, opposed this, and demanded that the additional territories remain under Syrian control. The Maronite community and the French disagreed, asserting that the new boundaries of "Greater Lebanon" formed the natural frontiers of Lebanon. The

LEBANON AND THE LONG CONFLICT

1920: Greater Lebanon created under French mandate

1943: National Pact shapes sectarian power-sharing

1975–1990: Civil war devastates the country

1982: Israel invades Lebanon

2000: Israeli withdrawal from southern Lebanon

2006: Full-scale Israel-Hezbollah war

2026: Lebanon again pulled into a regional war

signed in Taif, Saudi Arabia, was designed to end the 15-year Lebanese Civil War (1975–1990). It restructured Lebanon's political system by reallocating power from the Maronite Christian presidency to a more balanced cabinet and an evenly split (50-50) parliament between Christians and Muslims.

ISRAELI OCCUPATION OF LEBANON

Hezbollah, a Shi'i militia based in southern Lebanon, emerged during the Lebanese Civil War to resist the entrance of the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) into the war and its invasion of Lebanon from the south. It was permitted to keep its arms after the war, ostensibly to counter the Israeli occupation of southern Lebanon (1982–2000). In 1985, Hezbollah called for armed struggle to end the Israeli occupation of Lebanese territory. It has since played a central role in both the sectarian dynamics of Lebanon and periodic conflicts with Israel, particularly during the 2006 Lebanon War (between Israel and Hezbollah) and the Israel-Hezbollah War since 2023.

Israel's main objective under Ariel Sharon's invasion of Lebanon in 1982, "Operation Peace for Galilee", was political in nature; Tel Aviv sought to engineer politics by installing a pro-Israel government in Beirut through an alliance with the Maronite Christian group led by Bashir Gemayel. The ambition at that time was a Lebanon that would become an official peace partner, although this strategy ultimately collapsed after Gemayel's assassination and dragged Israel into an 18-year occupation.

Compared to 1982, Israel's military aggression into Lebanese territory since March 2026 has become a manifestation of a far more ambitious shift in Tel Aviv's security doctrine. The operation, which began following the assassination of Iran's supreme leader in "Operation Epic Fury", has developed into a large-scale ground invasion involving the mobilisation of hundreds of thousands of personnel, a figure that reflects Israel's absolute priority to reorganise the regional map. Tel Aviv no longer hides behind narrow defensive rhetoric. The deployment of ground forces that began on March 16, 2026, openly targets control of territory up to the Litani River, which covers around 10 per cent of Lebanon's total land area. Israel is effectively cutting off the geographic lifeline of southern Lebanon from the rest of the country.

Ecatarina Matoi, a scholar at the Middle East Political and Economic Institute (MEPEI), argues that Israel's current offensives, particularly its ground incursion in Lebanon, could be seen as part of a broader strategy aligned with the "Greater Israel" concept which envisions an Israel stretching from the Nile to the Euphrates, encompassing parts of Egypt, Lebanon, Jordan, Syria, Iraq, Saudi Arabia and beyond. It appears that Israel is no longer preoccupied with seeking local allies to manage Lebanon. Instead, Israel is applying what can be called the "Gaza Model" in southern Lebanon.



TO UNDERSTAND LEBANON'S VULNERABILITY, ONE MUST LOOK *beyond headlines* TO ITS FRACTURED POLITICS, LEGACY OF OCCUPATION AND REGIONAL RIVALRIES



When a Comeback Faces New Reality

Renault's Duster has returned with its old-school grit intact, but it has to prove that its driving brilliance still matters in a feature-obsessed Indian SUV market

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

A legacy is facing scrutiny. Because while some cars return quietly, Renault's Duster has stormed back with history on its shoulders and expectations under its bonnet. When it first arrived at the Auto Expo in 2012, it didn't just sell well. It rewired consumer thinking, turning the SUV from an aspirational oddity into an attainable default. But the segment that the Duster fathered has since mutated.

The crossover SUV segment is now far more sophisticated. It is far less forgiving too. The new Duster drives into a minefield dominated by the urbane polish of the Hyundai Creta, the tech-laden appeal of the Kia Seltos and the efficiency-first pitch of hybrids like the Suzuki Grand Vitara and Toyota Hyryder.

In 2012, the Duster wrote the definition of compact SUVs. It was rugged, affordable and practical. But today's market is crowded and demanding. The SUV is not competing with rivals now; it is fighting its own legacy. For this is no longer a segment that rewards rugged honesty alone, it rewards theatre too.



FORM AND FUNCTION

The new Duster, to its credit and stubbornness, refuses to dance along to the changed tune. It retains a boxy, upright stance, shunning the coupe-SUV affectations that dominate showroom floors. It looks like what it claims to be: an SUV. There is intent behind this design. With 212 mm of ground clearance and practical approach and departure angles, the Duster remains engineered for imperfect roads, not Instagram frames. Yet, therein lies a paradox. In a market where aesthetics drive purchase decisions, the Duster's functional purity may appeal, but only to a narrow audience.

The drive DNA could prove to be a deciding factor. For behind the wheel, the Duster begins to make its most compelling argument – not with features, but with its on-road feel. The 1.3-litre turbo petrol engine, pushing upwards of 160 bhp and 280 Nm, delivers performance that is not merely adequate, but unaffectedly engaging. Acceleration feels eager, overtakes are made with authority and the engine sounds refined enough to fade into the background when cruising.

Mind you, I haven't driven the car myself, yet. And Renault will surely correct this crime(!) soon. But my fellow reviewers and the SUV's specs tell a clear story. Most love the way the Duster moves. On broken roads, it is nonchalant. Potholes, ruts and speed breakers are absorbed with a composure that borders on indifference.



A SUPERB RIDE, STRONG TURBO PERFORMANCE AND *real-road ability* STAND OUT; BUT INTERIOR POLISH AND THE LACK OF A DIESEL ENGINE COULD LIMIT ITS RESURGENCE

at speed, adds to the ease, though motorheads may crave more feedback. In essence, the new Duster assures you that it remembers its place of birth, and that it has learned well enough to endure in its new avatar.

CABIN COMPROMISE

Inside, the transformation is evident. Sadly, it is also incomplete. The cabin is undeniably modern, with digital displays, large screen, connected technology and features like ventilated seats and a panoramic sunroof. The Duster is finally part

of the conversation. Yet, if you step into a Creta or Seltos soon after, the gaps are apparent. Those cars are richer, indulgent, almost theatrical in their look and feel.

The Duster, by contrast, leans toward utility. The plastics, especially in lower variants, shout that this is a car built to endure, not so much to impress. For some, that will be honesty. For others, it will be a compromise. But there are no tradeoffs made under the bonnet. Renault has leaned into petrol and hybrid powertrains, aligning with regulatory shifts and urban demand. The turbo-petrol delivers great efficiency (17-18 km per litre depending on transmission), plus strong performance. The upcoming hybrid variant, already witnessing strong bookings, signals where the market is headed.

But the absence of a diesel will be felt. For highway drivers and semi-urban buyers, diesel is practical and provides mental peace. Its omission is not just a technical choice, it seems to be a strategic gamble.

MARKET MISMATCH

There is another challenge, one that lies beyond spec sheets. The SUV buyer has evolved, from seeking capability to relying on looks, touch and feel. Today's buyer wants a car that feels premium, connected and aspirational. Features are not conveniences; they are currency. The Duster's proposition – robust, comfortable and capable – is compelling, but it speaks to a specific audience. One that values substance over spectacle. The

question that pops up is: how large is that audience in 2026? Renault's brand perception and after-sales footprint may also muddle matters. In a segment where trust and resale value weigh astronomically, these soft factors may influence buying decisions as much as horsepower, ground clearance and reliability (the new Duster comes with a seven-year warranty).

THE HARD TRUTH

Yet, despite some compromises, the Duster does something rare: it feels authentic. Drive it on bad roads and it comes alive. Push it on highways and it settles into an effortless rhythm. Live with it and it reveals a depth that spec sheets do not capture. This is not the most feature-rich SUV. It is not the most premium. It is not even the most efficient. But it is certainly one of the most honest.

Safety and platform improvements are a step forward. Built on a modern architecture, the new Duster has multiple airbags, electronic stability control and ADAS in the higher variants. This brings it closer to segment expectations, especially with safety being a key buying criterion. Pricing will also be a strategic advantage. Priced below or in line with key rivals, the Duster offers a compelling value proposition, especially for those who prioritise mechanical strength over feature overload.

For Renault, the path ahead is clear. Build on the new Duster's driving strength and character. Raise the cabin experience. Expand the ownership ecosystem. Do a juggle with a 4x4 or AWD. Reconsider the powertrain mix for a wider audience. Because in a market that is chasing gloss, the Duster offers grit. This leads to a mortal question is: Does India, in 2026, have room for both?

WELLNESS

UNDERSTANDING THE PERSONALITY SPECTRUM



Personality is no longer just introvert-extrovert, as ambiverts and otroverts redefine how we understand social energy and connection

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

between connection and independence.

THE OTROVERT: THE OUTSIDER WITHIN THE CROWD

This is a newer, less-discussed category called the otrovert. The word itself draws from "otro," meaning "other," reflecting a fundamental sense of standing slightly outside collective identity.

The term "otrovert" was coined by Dr Rami Kaminski.

OTROVERTS:

- Prefer one-on-one or small, meaningful interactions;
- Value independence and emotional self-reliance;
- Can appear extroverted in structured settings;
- Often feel like observers rather than participants.

They may attend social events, contribute, and even lead, but internally, there is a sense of being slightly "outside" the collective. Unlike ambiverts, who shift between introversion and extroversion, otroverts remain consistently independent in identity, regardless of context.

We have all asked this at some point: "Am I an introvert or an extrovert?"

It feels like a clean binary. You are either someone who loves people or someone who prefers solitude. But the truth is that human personality rarely operates in binaries. It exists on a spectrum, shaped not just by traits but by energy patterns, emotional needs, and attachment styles.

Somewhere between "I need people to feel alive" and "I need silence to function" lie two often overlooked identities: ambiverts and otroverts, which can better capture how most of us relate to the world.

THE INTROVERT: ENERGY IS INTERNAL

Introversion is often mistaken for shyness. It is not about fear of people. It is about energy conservation.

INTROVERTS TEND TO:

- Feel drained after prolonged social interaction;
- Prefer meaningful conversations over small talk and reflect before speaking;
- Need solitude to recharge.

After a social event, the instinct is not to extend the evening but to withdraw and reset.

From an attachment perspective, many introverts are comfortable with emotional self-sufficiency. They are not anti-social; they are selectively social, investing deeply but not widely.

THE EXTROVERT: ENERGY IS EXTERNAL

Extroverts operate in the opposite direction. They are energised by interaction. Social engagement is not effort; instead, it is fuel.

THEY TEND TO:

- Feel more alive around people;
- Think out loud;
- Enjoy group settings;
- Find silence uncomfortable.

After a long day alone, their instinct is to seek connection.

Psychologically, extroverts often process emotions through externalisation.

THE AMBIVERT: THE ADAPTIVE MIDDLE

Most people do not sit at either extreme. They fluctuate on the spectrum.

AMBIVERTS:

- Enjoy socialising, but in moderation;
- Can be expressive or reserved depending on context;
- Adjust their energy based on the environment.

They may enjoy a gathering but also look forward to leaving it.

Ambiverts are often effective in relationships and leadership because they can read the room and adapt. From an attachment lens, they tend to have more flexible regulation, moving

FOR DECADES, personality has been reduced to a simple question — are you an introvert or an extrovert?

In attachment terms, this reflects a strong non-conformist, self-defined orientation—not avoidance, but a lack of need for belonging in the conventional sense. Someone who can engage socially, but does not feel psychologically "part of the group."

WHY DID WE NEED A NEW TERM?

Traditional personality models—introvert, extrovert, ambivert—focus largely on energy gain and loss.

BUT THEY DO NOT FULLY CAPTURE:

- The experience of not identifying with groups;
- The ability to engage socially without emotional merging;
- The preference for individuality over belonging.

Otroversion fills this gap. It speaks less about energy and more about identity orientation.

IS PERSONALITY FIXED?

These are not rigid labels. They are patterns of regulation.

Your position on this spectrum can shift based on life stage, emotional load, environment, and relationship safety. When you feel secure, you may appear more extroverted. When overwhelmed, more introverted. When self-defined and independent, more outgoing.

Attachment plays a central role in this movement.

The goal is not to become more extroverted or more introverted. The goal is to know when to engage, to know when to withdraw, and to stop pathologising yourself, because your personality is not a limitation. It is your strategy for navigating connections.

Stories Behind Statistics

*A compelling blend of numbers and storytelling, Rohit Saran's **100 Ways to See India** turns data into insight, challenging assumptions and revealing surprising truths about India's complex realities*

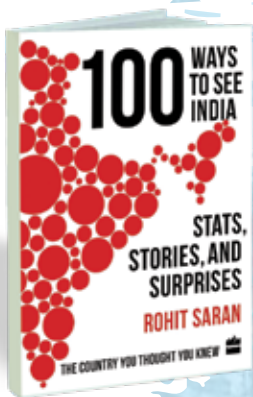


From India's linguistic diversity to the number of Indians paying income tax, the likely fallouts of the current census, and how migrants are driving India's economy, there is one 'go-to book': *100 Ways to See India: Stats, Stories and Surprises* by Rohit Saran. It helps place facts in perspective, demolish many a shibboleth, and offer fresh insights into the many things that define the everyday reality of the world's fastest-growing economy.

Statistics are boring and, more often than not, put the reader to sleep, but this book is different. Each data set is accompanied by an easy-to-understand graph or chart and a story that makes one pause, think, and say, 'I didn't know that!'. The illustrations challenge assumptions on both sides of the ideological spectrum, for, as Joan Robinson said about India, 'whatever you can rightly say about India, the opposite is equally true'.

Let's start with language. During the last census (of 2011), Indians listed 1,95,691 mother tongues to their enumerators, multiple times the officially listed 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule. By August next year, when the results of the next count are published, we will know whether this number has gone down or remained constant. Although Hindi is understood by 57 per cent (69 crore) of the population, only 52 crore speak it as their first language. The rate of population growth has certainly been arrested, and by 2050, India's population graph will also start its downward journey. In percentage terms, all religions, except Islam, have declined; Islam has increased from 9.8 per cent to 15.2 per cent from 1951 to 2025. When it comes to political power, we have to go granular and look at legislators in state and UT assemblies. The BJP holds 40 per cent of the MLAs, followed by 38.4 per cent of the regional and Left parties. This leaves the Congress with less than 22 per cent of political representation at the state level. Contrary to popular perception, India is not a vegetarian country—over 87 per cent of men and 75 per

cent of



81%

INDIANS CONSUME MEAT, CHALLENGING THE NOTION OF A PREDOMINANTLY VEGETARIAN NATION

43%

INDIANS DO NOT PRIMARILY SPEAK HINDI, UNDERLINING THE COUNTRY'S DEEP LINGUISTIC DIVERSITY

women relish meat, though large numbers avoid beef and pork. However, poultry has expanded 12 times—Indians are eating more eggs and broilers than ever before.

Getting into India's civil services is tougher than making it to Harvard or becoming an astronaut with NASA. Interestingly, while 76 per cent of aspirants come from engineering, science, or medicine, 85 per cent choose four optional papers—political science, geography, sociology, and anthropology. Although more men appear for the exam than women, their success ratio is substantially higher. In fact, since 2010, girls have been out-enrolling boys in schools. But when it comes to dating, women prefer those closer to their age cohort, while men show a marked

preference for younger women. When Shah Rukh Khan debuted in Bollywood in 1992, his future co-star Deepika Padukone was all of six years old.

Let us now look at some of the great ironies of India. In 2011, over eleven million urban homes were vacant, even as many times that number were living in unauthorised JJ clusters. We are told that globally, cities like Vancouver and Washington, D.C., tax empty houses to promote affordable rentals. Should India follow suit? Meanwhile, five states—Maharashtra, Gujarat, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Uttar Pradesh—are all vying with each other to become India's first trillion-dollar state.

The report also celebrates India's partial victory over inflation. In each decade after Independence, India

saw at least two years of double-digit inflation. But after 2015, the RBI and the government signed a landmark agreement to formally keep inflation in check, setting a goal of 4 per cent per annum, with an upper limit of 6 per cent in extraordinary circumstances. Most economists agree that price stability is the forerunner to prosperity. But measuring prosperity is not as simple as it may appear. There is notional per capita GDP, inflation-adjusted GDP, GDP with respect to USD, and GDP with respect to PPP, and it is by the latter count that India becomes a middle-income country in terms of the affordability of goods and services. It is also interesting to note that at the time of the Kargil war, Pakistan's per capita income was higher than India's; by 2005, it was equal, and now it is less than

half. The war on poverty is certainly one that Pakistan has lost to India—without a single bullet being fired.

In fact, mobile phones and data are perhaps the cheapest in India—for the cost of mobile data fell by over 90 per cent in the last decade, thereby spiking data consumption by a factor of over 656 per cent. Another interesting data set is about the average spending of a foreign tourist in India vis-à-vis Europe. The European and trans-Atlantic visitor takes longer to come to India and, therefore, spends more time here than they would in

a neighbouring country.

We now come to the great poverty dilemma of India. By June 2025, India had eliminated absolute poverty, and on December 1, 2025, Kerala became the first state to declare itself 'poverty-free'. However, even as India has significantly reduced the number of poor people, inequality—rather, extreme inequality—is on the rise, which is a larger policy issue for the political economy to dwell upon. One consequence of poverty is that people 'vote with their feet': they migrate to greener pastures. This explains why Delhi is Bihar's second-largest city, just as Toronto is for Punjab. Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, and Jharkhand also continue to be states with high birth rates—and they will supply labour to Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Punjab. Soon, surnames like Jha, Paswan, Mandal, and Yadav will be on the electoral rolls of these states, even as migrants learn to speak Tamil, Marathi, Gujarati, and Punjabi with flourish and contest for seats in municipal councils and legislative assemblies.

The entries on sports also make for a fascinating read. That India dominates cricket is well known, but it is in the game of chess that India has made real strides. In 1990, India had just one grandmaster—Viswanathan Anand. Today, India has over 90 grandmasters, and in November 2025, it was the only country in the world with three men in the top ten in classical chess—aged 19, 20, and 22. Women have not lagged behind, and we have two dozen of them as well. With India making a pitch for the 2036 Olympics, the country is gearing up to prove its mettle as a sporting nation too.

Last, but not least, the book tells us where to access big data. It lists the Parliament, RBI, Census of India, MoSPI, the Ministries of Health, Agriculture, and Education, NCRB, the World Bank, and NITI Aayog websites, along with popular search engines like Google and social media platforms like X as sources. But none of them will give you half the joy that this book does.

Go ahead, grab a copy, and win any quiz on India!

INLAND

Limits of Climate Modelling

In the second part of this article, we look into the inherent limitations that continue to challenge climate models

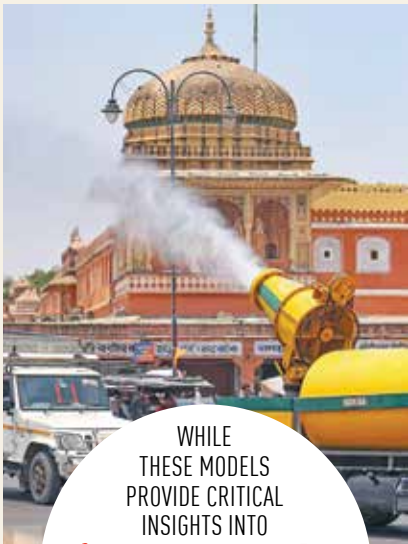


Running climate models and interpreting their output has to be handled carefully and is beset with many challenges, such as:

Sensitivity to initial conditions: Weather prediction models are highly sensitive to initial conditions because they deal with short-term predictions. Climate models, however, deal with long-term average trends and are therefore less sensitive to initial conditions, something referred to as the butterfly effect or chaos theory. To get around this issue, climate models are run many times, or in an ensemble.

Non-linear nature of climate change: Climate change and climate models are non-linear in nature (which means that the relation between cause and effect is not proportional: a small change can lead to an abrupt and massive consequence). For example, the ice-albedo feedback, where a small rise in average global temperature leads to the melting of ice on land and in the seas, means that a darker Earth and ocean absorb more solar radiation, leading to further warming.

Parameterisations: As noted above, climate models deal with long-term prediction of averages. In a typical model, a grid is 100 km by 100 km, and a time step is 10–30 minutes. These models cover a large geographical area and therefore cannot include localised phenomena such as rainfall, ocean currents, and cloud formation. To include them



WHILE THESE MODELS PROVIDE CRITICAL INSIGHTS INTO *future risks*, THEY ALSO CARRY LIMITATIONS ROOTED IN PHYSICS, COMPUTATION AND INCOMPLETE UNDERSTANDING

in models, their aggregate impact on the grid is approximated through mathematical equations. In other words, the effect of sub-grid phenomena such as clouds and rainfall is approximated for the whole grid.

Micro-initialisation issues: These, as distinct from specifying initial conditions, require that a variable (e.g., temperature) be given a slightly different value in one grid, so that different pathways result as an outcome of ensemble climate modelling.

Initial macro-level conditions: These are basically the global properties of the Earth, ocean, and atmosphere (temperature, pressure, humidity, wind speed, surface temperature of oceans, etc.) and boundary conditions, or external 'forcings', such as a rise in greenhouse gases and volcanic activity, which change continuously and affect the climate system from the outside.

We have mostly discussed aspects of the atmosphere in climate models. However, a comprehensive climate model, such as Earth System Models, also has to include oceans, land, ice sheets, and glaciers. Again, the ocean and land are also divided into 3D grids, and a set of equations is solved for each grid. Here again, there are many aspects of climate that are dealt with through parameterisation. Incorporating the carbon cycle, ice sheets, and glaciers into GCMs gives us more comprehensive ESMs, as discussed above.

Even after we take into account the above issues, there is uncertainty in climate predictions from these models. Many climate scientists run hundreds of simulations with a view to reducing uncertainty. One of the largest simulation efforts was conducted by David Stainforth and his team in the

Climateprediction.net project, which carried out a hundred thousand simulations. Stainforth, however, says that probability distributions suggested by such "model versions" or simulations have limited value in predicting long-term climate; at best, they put a lower bound on the uncertainty. He also warns against the large amounts of parameterisations that climate models have to resort to: they are just approximations and are not based on fundamental physics. As a result, different climate models use different approaches to parameterisation.

The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change uses such models, as well as the many Coupled Model Intercomparison Projects (CMIP), to get some idea about policy in various socio-economic areas. However, at the end of the day, climate models are just that: models representing reality, but not reality itself. They are not exact, but they do provide a basis to take forward research.

CONCLUSION

With a rise in computing power, many sophisticated and comprehensive climate models with greater resolution are being built. While these models do take forward research on the complex subject of climate science, we are still left with the basic question: what to do with the output of such models when applying them to real-world economic policies and steps to mitigate and adapt to climate change. We will discuss this in the coming articles.





Relentless Icons Fearless Kids

AUTHOR



S KANNAN

As IPL expands across geographies and talent pools, rising stars and ageing greats together define a tournament that mirrors India's changing cricketing ecosystem

A fortnight into the 2026 edition of the Indian Premier League, the craze for T20 cricket at home is at its peak. Truly a permanent fixture in the calendar since 2008, nothing has diminished interest in the IPL, despite the many changes introduced to expand the reach of this mass sport.

The other day, when 15-year-old 'wunderkind' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi took on numero uno Jasprit Bumrah with aplomb in Guwahati, the rain-reduced contest between Rajasthan Royals and Mumbai Indians showed how a youngster handles pressure on the big stage.

Just last year, Sooryavanshi had already shown more than a glimpse of his talent, potential, and fearlessness on the big stage. The IPL is different in many ways. After all, a young teenager taking on 32-year-old Bumrah was a match-up that ensured adrenaline levels were high. Jeez, the way the 15-year-old boy from Bihar, who has grown manifold in stature over the last year, stood up to attack Bumrah was ferocious.

Watching the body language of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, it is clear he is fearless and will play his strokes. With no inhibition, ready to decode Bumrah's variety and willing to play high-risk shots without compromising on technique, this boy is turning out to be a real treasure. For those who said last year that he needs to be wrapped in cotton wool, there is no fear. Having played for his state, Bihar, and also performed well in India's triumph in the ICC Under-19 World Cup this year, Vaibhav—as his mates call him—has a future. For those who feared he might get burnt out, be assured that the Rajasthan Royals have handled him well.

There have been a few changes this season, notably with ownership shifts at the Rajasthan Royals as well as the Royal Challengers Bengaluru. Actual cricket in an IPL franchise is just one part; what happens behind the scenes in business terms is quite another. Certainly, for players belonging to these franchises after being bought at auction, there is no cause for worry. In fact, Rajasthan Royals have done even better this year, though why they chose Guwahati as a home away from home baffles a few.

It is well known that the IPL is both growing and evolving. The Rajasthan side did face a few issues with

authorities in their home state, so embracing Guwahati—which is also the city from where BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia hails—has made it a popular destination. For those who have not travelled to the North Eastern states and casually remark on social media that it gets dark at 4:30 pm, how does that even matter? A floodlit match begins around 7:30 pm, so even after rain, an 11-over-a-side contest at the Baraspara Cricket Stadium featuring two top teams—MI and RR—was encouraging. It showed that despite the rains, there is a proper drainage system and good covers. Looking ahead, the same venue will also host one of the Test matches in the India versus Australia series in 2027.

There are some who are complaining that a historic Test venue like Kolkata has been ignored. Truth be told, cricket in India is growing, and the emergence of more international venues is a positive sign. One must not forget that even Riyan Parag, the Rajasthan Royals captain, hails from Assam. It must be acknowledged that today's cricketers

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CRICKET

no longer come only from big cities. This is a positive development—cricket is now played across India, and mofussil towns are producing immense talent, such as Sameer Rizvi. He plays for the Delhi Capitals and is exciting to watch.

Why are these changes happening? For most people, the most visible form of club cricket is the IPL. Now, with several states boasting their own T20 leagues for both men and women, the explosion in cricket is massive. That the T20 format has become a mass sport is no exaggeration. It is also the reason why cricket will feature as a medal sport at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. State cricket leagues are equally attractive and professionally managed. Imagine Kerala, where athletics and football were once dominant—today it has a thriving T20 league.

Returning to the success story of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, several youngsters have made their mark in the 2026 IPL. Ayush Mhatre, the 18-year-old from Mumbai, has delivered for the Chennai Super Kings. Before one hears a sarcastic remark—CSK may not have peaked this season—but that does not

RISE OF NEW INDIA CRICKET

The IPL's footprint is no longer limited to metropolitan centres. Cities like Guwahati are emerging as credible venues, while players from smaller towns—Assam, Bihar, and beyond—are taking centre stage. With state T20 leagues flourishing, cricket's grassroots have deepened, ensuring a steady pipeline of talent that reflects India's diversity.

diminish Mhatre's contribution, now in his second year. As captain of the Indian Under-19 side that won the World Cup, he knows the importance of consistent performance.

If he continues in the same vein, there is no reason why he—or Sooryavanshi—will not soon represent the Indian senior team. Yes, the IPL is club cricket, but youngsters understand the importance of performing in domestic cricket across formats to be noticed. Vaibhav has already done so in the preceding first-class season for Bihar.

So, is the focus only on young Turks, or do the golden oldies still hold their ground? Two prime examples of seasoned stars who continue to stay fit and competitive are Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. The criticism both former India captains have faced from the media and social media has been relentless. With only ODIs left as their international format, both Kohli and Rohit—representing RCB and MI respectively—know they must keep delivering.

Kohli's fitness, belief in his skills, and passion remain incredible. He is to RCB what MS Dhoni is to CSK. Though he has stepped down as captain, Kohli remains the face of RCB. There was uncertainty before the IPL regarding whether RCB would play in Bengaluru and whether the change in ownership would affect the team. Clearly, boardroom developments have not impacted on-field performance. Whether the team's name changes in the future remains to be seen, but one thing is certain—Virat Kohli continues to embody the franchise and maintains peak fitness.

Competing in the IPL is not easy. Travel, night matches, long schedules, and recovery make it physically demanding. Yet Kohli's ability to maintain fitness and set an example is admirable. In recent times, Kohli and his wife, Anushka Sharma, have embraced spirituality. In a cricket-obsessed country where media scrutiny is intense, finding inner calm and staying focused is no small task—and Kohli appears to have found that balance.

For those who claim Kohli is in the twilight of his career, try stopping him. He continues to bat with intensity and energy. The bigger picture is the ICC ODI World Cup in 2027 in South

Africa. Having stepped away from T20 internationals, Kohli knows the 50-over format is where he has excelled, much like Sachin Tendulkar before him. For those who still say he is ageing, just watch him in the IPL.

If Kohli remains driven, Rohit Sharma—who turns 39 at the end of April—has shown renewed focus on fitness. By shedding weight, working on strength, and improving agility, the "Hitman" has impressed many. With a clear objective, he wants to play regularly for the Mumbai Indians, not just as an Impact Player. He has worked hard to stay relevant and is determined to prove himself repeatedly.

Like Kohli, Rohit is also eyeing the 2027 ODI World Cup. Keeping this in mind, the BCCI has scheduled several ODIs this year after the IPL. The idea is that, just as India's T20 World Cup campaign required preparation, the ODI format now demands similar focus. From a fan's perspective, watching Kohli and Rohit put in long hours in training, remain agile, and fight for their places is exemplary. These two are role models in the truest sense, and seeing them perform in both the IPL and ODIs is a delight.

As for the growing emphasis on youth in sports, one must not dismiss seasoned players as relics of the past. Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma still have a great deal to offer to cricket at large.



AYUSH MHATRE



VAIBHAV SOORYAVANSHI



SAMEER RIZVI

I don't wait for the NEXT SCRIPT

Mona Singh is on a roll and 2026 looks truly like her year

KOMAL PANCHAMATIA

Mona Singh is on a roll and 2026 looks truly like her year. Flooded with exciting offers, Singh said she consciously filters her scripts to find challenging roles that give her sleepless nights.

Over the past few months, Singh has displayed incredible range as an actor across films and OTT shows. After playing a protective mother in 'The Ba**ds of Bollywood', she effortlessly pivoted to playing a quirky Goan gangster in 'Happy Patel: Khatarnak Jasoos', a devoted army wife of a soldier in 'Border 2', a grieving cop hunting down criminals in 'Kohrra 2' and a ruthless sand mafia queen in 'Subedar'.

Singh said what people see as success is a result of the right choices. "I don't wait for the next script. I wait for the right one, which strikes a chord, which gives me more room to play and more exposure to experiment and challenge me as an actor. It has to give me those sleepless nights. I have to be a little jittery before getting onto the set. I have to feel all that," Singh, who has also garnered acclaim for her work in films like '3 Idiots', 'Laal Singh Chaddha', 'Munjiya' and series, 'Made in Heaven', told PTI.

Having multiple releases in a short span of time often sparks fear of exposure in actors, but the 44-year-old actor said she has not experienced a 'too much ho gaya' moment yet. "It's the variety of roles. I'm not repeating myself. Thankfully, I'm getting all these different opportunities, different roles to play. I never get scared about the fact that, 'oh, I'm going to be out there or too much ho gaya (exposure)'," Singh said.

The actress said she ensures she pats herself when the job is well done. "I'm very



FLOODED WITH EXCITING OFFERS, SHE CONSCIOUSLY FILTERS *her scripts* TO FIND CHALLENGING ROLES THAT GIVE HER SLEEPLESS NIGHTS

kind to myself," she said, adding that she doesn't wear a fake mask of positivity all the time either. So, today if I'm low, tomorrow I won't be, but I need to address it; I don't escape it. I think that's the way to live your life. Sometimes people are like, 'Don't show your emotions' but I show my emotions. Life is supposed to hit you, cast all shadows on you and hence,

you play these kinds of layered roles. You cannot be playing these roles while living a little. You've got to live a

life," the actor said.

Singh said she knows how to handle her downtime and added that she gets back to her restaurant business, travels, practices yoga, tends to her garden and pets. "I know life is more than just working and doing your job and acting," she said, adding, "Wherever I am, I'm just present 100 per cent. Nothing takes a toll on me, that 'Too much ho gaya. I need a break. I manage my breaks pretty well.'"

Singh has the 'Prime Video' series 'Maa Ka Sum', gangster crime drama show 'Paan Parda Zarda' and Rajkumar Hirani's debut OTT show with Vikrant Massey.

In 'Maa Ka Sum', she plays a mother to 'The Archies' actor Mihir Ahuja. While Singh has portrayed a mother before, she said this character is different from her past roles.

Singh and Ahuja previously played mother and son in 'Made in Heaven' season two. "I've played a mother before, but she's so new in 'Maa Ka Sum', she is so progressive and that's what I love (about the show). Also, I'm choosing projects, which are not just commercially viable, but they're also conversation starters, like 'Maa Ka Sum'," Singh, who has played the role of a mother in 'The Ba**ds of Bollywood' and 'Laal Singh Chaddha', said.

'Maa Ka Sum' follows the story of a 19-year-old math genius (Ahuja), who attempts to apply mathematical principles to find his mother (Singh), a perfect romantic match, only to learn that human connections transcend formulas. The eight-episode light-hearted drama is directed by Nicholas Kharkongor.

AGENCIES



SENSE AND SENSIBILITY

Returning to the Himalayas

AUTHOR



BY SUPRIYA NEWAR

Kanchenjunga remains where it has always been - immovable, indifferent and quietly magnificent

There is a moment in the film 'Kanchenjunga' that has always amused me. A character, played by Pahari Sanyal, is deeply absorbed in birdwatching, binoculars in place and attention sharpened to a fine point. Another, played by Chhabhi Biswas, watches this flurry of earnest activity with mild bemusement and asks, almost dismissively, "Roast kora jaaye?" - can the bird be roasted? If not, he sees little point in the exercise.

I was reminded of that exchange recently, not in a cinema hall, but high up in the Himalayas.

At nearly 10,000 feet, in a small, unassuming lodge, the days had a way of stretching and softening at the edges. Mornings arrive crisp and blue, the kind that gently insists you step outside, if only to stand still and take in the sight of Kanchenjunga gleaming in the distance. By afternoon, the mist would roll in like an uninvited but familiar guest and the sun would retreat into a game of quiet hide and seek. There were cups of freshly brewed French press coffee - unexpected at that altitude - books that asked to be read slowly and the comforting weight of a thick quilt that made you reluctant to leave its fold. I have been going to the Himalayas since I was a child. The mountains, in that sense, are far from new to me. And yet, they never quite repeat themselves. Or perhaps, more accurately, I do not.

Kanchenjunga remains where it has always been - immovable, indifferent and quietly magnificent. But the eyes that return to it carry a different lens each time. What once felt like awe now carries a shade of stillness. What was earlier excitement has melted into something more reflective. The mountain doesn't change; the gaze does. And somewhere in that subtle shift lies the quiet reason one returns - not to see something new, but to see differently - to soak in its quiet reassurance.



My days there were unhurried. I wandered into nearby villages without a map, trusting instinct more than direction. Conversations unfolded in half-broken Nepali with children who seemed far less bothered by linguistic accuracy than I was. I watched prayer flags converse with the breeze, their quiet flutter carrying something that did not need translation. There was no checklist, no urgency - just the gentle act of being present, of allowing the place to reveal itself at its own pace. Sharing this space, however, were others who were experiencing the very same landscape in a markedly different way.

They were avid bird watchers. Their mornings began earlier, their movements sharper and their purpose clearly defined. Equipped with cameras and lenses that looked capable of doubling up as gym equipment, binoculars slung with familiarity, they set out with a focus that was almost admirable in its intensity. There was energy, antici-

pation and an unmistakable thrill in the air. A sighting - a raptor, a thrush, a magpie, a sunbird - would be met with hushed excitement, sometimes even a triumphant whisper. Each moment felt earned, each discovery precise.

We occupied the same geography, woke up to the same mountain, breathed the same crisp air - and yet, inhabited entirely different experiences of it.

For me, the joy lay in returning - in recognising, in lingering and in allowing the familiar to deepen rather than dazzle. For them, it was in the pursuit of locating, identifying and momentarily holding something elusive before it slipped away again. Neither seemed incomplete. Neither seemed superior, just different ways of entering the same vastness. The only bird that I saw every day without fail was the village rooster, calling ritually at daybreak as it scurried about, its plumage a bright red, almost making it look like jungle fowl.

It struck me then that places don't offer a singular experience. They respond instead to the temperament we arrive with. Some of us seek to dissolve into a landscape, to let it seep in slowly and quietly. Others engage with it more actively, drawing out its details, naming them, framing them and celebrating them in bursts of discovery. The mountain, indifferent to these preferences, accommodates both.

Some arrive with binoculars and some with the fragrance of memory. Some scan the horizon for movement; others sit still and let it come to them. And somewhere between the two, without choosing sides, the mountain remains as it was - resolute, reminding us that there is more than one way to see and no single way to belong.

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THE SLOW DEATH OF PRINT MEDIA IN THE GULF



The two print media giants of Dubai, 'Khaleej Times' and 'Gulf News', are gasping for breath, with advertising revenue drying up like raindrops on desert sand

ASIF ULLAH KHAN

The two print media giants of Dubai, 'Khaleej Times' and 'Gulf News', are gasping for breath, with advertising revenue drying up like raindrops on desert sand. Despite their efforts to stave off the inevitable, the relentless rise of digital media has been eating away at both advertisements and readership, hollowing out these once-formidable institutions like termites consuming a solid tree.

Both papers discontinued their print editions on Saturdays and Sundays on June 3, 2023. The decision to stop weekend printing was driven by declining advertising revenue, increased costs for paper and logistics and a shift in consumer habits toward digital platforms. Digital content continues to be available over the weekend.

For years, the decline was gradual, almost deniable. Management strategies, cost-cutting measures and digital pivots offered temporary relief. But the last straw, many believe, was the ill-fated US-Israel-Iran conflict, whose ripple effects were felt sharply across Gulf economies. The region, despite having little direct stake in the confrontation, bore the economic brunt and with it came a further contraction in advertising, the lifeblood of print journalism.

Few voices capture this moment of reckoning more poignantly than Abdul Hamid Ahmad, former CEO and Editor-in-Chief of 'Gulf News'. Having witnessed waves of layoffs across both newspapers, Ahmad has, in many ways, penned what reads like an obituary for an entire industry.

In a deeply reflective 'LinkedIn' post, he wrote of grief, not just for colleagues who lost their jobs, but for a profession that once defined lives and identities. With nearly 45 years in journalism across magazines, newspapers and digital platforms, Ahmad draws a stark distinction: this isn't another cyclical downturn. "What we are seeing today is not a crisis," he observed. "It is an ending."

According to reports, the first casualties are the newsboys (as in India, where a news hawkker sells multiple papers). Both papers had separate teams of newsboys to distribute the paper. Next, the marketing and events teams have been reduced to a skeleton.

There was a time when newspapers were not merely businesses but institutions - thick with pages, rich in reporting and sustained by robust advertising. Publications like 'Gulf News' and 'Khaleej Times' routinely ran to 60, 70 and even 80 pages, shaping the daily rhythm of life in the UAE. Today, those same papers struggle to fill 16 thin pages, often padded with light content and starved of advertisements. The silence of those missing

pages speaks louder than any headline.

The reasons for this collapse are neither mysterious nor unique to the Gulf. They are the result of sweeping global shifts:

- ❖ Advertising has migrated to digital platforms, offering precision targeting and measurable returns.
- ❖ Readers have moved to mobile screens, guided by algorithm-driven feeds rather than editorial judgment.
- ❖ The economics of print - from production to distribution - have become untenable.
- ❖ Media ownership has shifted from growth-oriented investment to mere survival mode.

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Yet, as Ahmad underscores, the tragedy isn't institutional alone - it is deeply human. Behind every layoff lies a lifetime of craft: reporters who chased stories across decades, editors who mentored generations and photographers who chronicled a nation's evolution frame by frame. What is being dismantled is not just an industry, but a community and a culture.

What remains of these once-mighty publications is, increasingly, a shell. A Dubai-based journalist, who wishes to remain anonymous, said, "They are ghosts of their former selves... Most of the old staff are gone..." These are terrible times, he added.

Ahmad said survival has become dearer day after day and waiting for a mercy bullet feels like a waste of time. Newspapers that once shaped public opinion now struggle to justify their own existence.

Ahmad, who has spent 45 years in journalism, said, "Yet even in this bleak landscape, one truth remains: journalism itself isn't dying. The business model is. The craft is evolving, mutating, finding new forms - niche platforms, independent voices, multimedia storytelling. But the era of the grand newspaper, the thick morning edition, the bustling newsroom - that era is fading."

"For those of us who lived it, loved it and gave our lives to it, the loss is personal. It is the end of a world we helped build. And it deserves to be mourned," Ahmad concluded, grieving.

